

Delhi-Meerut Expressway to get variable speed limits from Aug 15

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a first-of-its-kind project, commuters using the Delhi-Meerut Expressway will encounter different speed limits depending on the travel hour from August 15, officials said on Wednesday. Passing through the key NCR cities such as Ghaziabad and Noida, the Delhi-Meerut Expressway (DME) has had the same speed limits for cars and heavy vehicles. Under the 'variable speed limit' pilot project, the speed limit on the Delhi side of the expressway will be subject to the congestion on the road.

As per the plan, between 12 and 7 am, the speed limit will be 65 kmph for cars and 50 kmph for heavy vehicles (HVs). From 7 am to 5 pm, it will be 55 kmph for cars and 45 kmph for HVs. Between 5 pm and 12 am, it will be 60 kmph and 40 kmph for cars and HVs, respectively. "The variable speed limit project will be implemented from August 15 between the Akshardham and Sarai Kale Khan stretch of the expressway in the first phase. This will be the first such project in the country," Satish Chandra, professor, Civil Engineering Department, IIT Roorkee, said. He is working

on the project with the Central Road Research Institute (CRRI). The existing speed signboards on DME have been either covered or blurred to avoid any confusion. The CRRI has also installed special sensors on the expressway to record the vehicular movement data. Chandra said, "The researchers studied 24-hour traffic data of the expressway over the past few months and then decided upon these speed limits. The main objective of the project is to reduce congestion and accidents on the roads. We will collect data after an interval of three months and asses the actual



effect of the project on the ground."

The National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), which manages the expressway, is the implementing

agency for the project.

A senior Delhi Traffic Police officer said the speed limits and any variation in them are based entirely on a scientific traffic study done by a dif-

ferent department and are aimed at improving road safety as well as traffic flow.

"So far, we have learnt that two digital variable speed limit display boards have been installed on separate foot overbridges along the Delhi stretch of the Delhi-Meerut Expressway. One has been installed near the Akshardham temple, and the other near the Pandav Nagar FOB. Our role is to monitor compliance and take action against motorists found overspeeding," the officer said.

Another police officer said that besides the variable speed limit display boards, speed detection cameras will

also be installed along the corridor, which will automatically enforce the speed limit displayed at a particular time, detect vehicles violating the prescribed limit and notify the drivers.

Officials have also noted that almost 20 per cent of the vehicles that use the expressway are heavy commercial vehicles. Meanwhile, the remaining 80 per cent are passenger vehicles. This large variation in vehicle types and speeds also creates bottlenecks. They particularly happen during busy hours.

Traffic studies have also found that between 7 am and 7 pm, the expressway

experiences consistently high traffic volumes. During the morning rush hour between 7 am and 9 am, vehicles may be travelling at speeds of around 100 kmph and 70 kmph simultaneously. However, congestion still develops because of the speed differences and increasing traffic density.

Similarly, during the evening, heavy traffic builds up around the Ring Road. This then results in long queues and slower movement. The proposed time-based speed limits are expected to reduce these speed variations and improve the overall flow of traffic.

Rains trigger waterlogging, traffic chaos across Capital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rainwater pooling on roads, vehicles inching through long traffic snarls and flooded stretches across several neighbourhoods turned Wednesday's showers into another difficult day of commute for Delhiites, as waterlogging disrupted movement in many parts of the national Capital for hours.

The rain left several roads submerged, slowing traffic across key corridors and affecting movement in different parts of the city.

Heavy congestion was reported on the Mehrauli-Badarpur Road, while commuters also faced slow-moving traffic at ITO, Mathura Road, Lodhi Road, parts of Lutyens' Delhi, Rohtak Road, the Shankar Road-Kirti Nagar stretch, the Delhi-Jaipur Highway, Madhuban Chowk, Peeragarhi and Shaheen Bagh.

Traffic movement was also affected in several parts of east Delhi, including GT Road,



Loni Road, Jhilmil, GTB Enclave and Dilshad Garden, where rainwater accumulation slowed vehicular movement.

Waterlogging was reported from multiple locations across the city, including the Mehrauli-Badarpur Road, where inundation persisted for several hours.

Stretches in Sangam Vihar, including Shani Bazaar Road, and Dakshin Puri also remained waterlogged, while flooding-like conditions were reported from

parts of south Delhi. Waterlogging was also reported from several areas in central Delhi.

The gallery of Safdarjung Hospital was filled with rainwater following the showers. According to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), three cases of tree felling were reported across the city between 6 am and 2 pm on Wednesday.

The MCD control room also received 10 complaints of waterlogging between 2 pm and 6 pm, with five com-

plaints each from the Central and South zones.

Many commuters took to social media to share videos and photographs of submerged roads and complain about waterlogging in areas such as CR Park, Sangam Vihar, Lodhi Road and several other localities, saying the inundated stretches made commuting difficult.

Between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, Safdarjung, the city's base weather station, recorded 15.6 mm of rainfall, while Lodhi Road received 38.7 mm. Palam recorded 1.4 mm, Ayanagar 0.2 mm and Ridge reported trace rainfall during the period.

Earlier, in the 24 hours ending at 8:30 am, Safdarjung recorded 10.8 mm of rainfall, Ayanagar 49.3 mm, Palam 8.3 mm, Lodhi Road 3.9 mm and Ridge 3.0 mm.

The maximum temperature settled at 32.6 degrees Celsius at Safdarjung, 31.0 degrees Celsius at Palam, 32.8 degrees Celsius at Lodi Road, 34.0 degrees Celsius at Ridge and 30.5 degrees Celsius at Ayanagar. It was 1.6

notches below normal at Safdarjung, 3.4 notches below normal at Palam, 0.2 notches below normal at Lodhi Road, normal at Ridge and 3.5 notches below normal at Ayanagar.

The India Meteorological Department has forecast a generally cloudy sky with moderate rain on Thursday.

The maximum and minimum temperatures are likely to settle around 32 degrees Celsius and 23 degrees Celsius, respectively. A yellow alert has been issued for the national Capital.

The minimum temperature was recorded at 26.6 degrees Celsius at Safdarjung, 24.9 degrees Celsius at Palam, 26.7 degrees Celsius at Lodhi Road, 23.8 degrees Celsius at Ridge and 25.9 degrees Celsius at Ayanagar. It was 0.3 notches below normal at Safdarjung, 1.9 notches below normal at Palam, 0.7 notch above normal at Lodi Road, 2.4 notches below normal at Ridge and 0.5 notch below normal at Ayanagar.

Health Minister issues notice over medicine procurement delay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Health Minister Pankaj Singh has issued a show-cause notice to the Secretary of the Health and Family Welfare Department over the alleged failure to submit a comprehensive action plan on pending procurement of medicines, consumables and medical equipment despite repeated directions, according to the notice.

The notice, issued on Tuesday, said the minister had first directed the department through an official communication dated May 26 to prepare and submit a comprehensive action plan with item-wise timelines for completion of all pending procurement processes. It also sought a review of timelines for submission of demands by health institutions.

According to the notice, after no response was received, another communication was issued on June 17 directing the department to



submit the action plan and report by June 19.

The notice said that as the information was still not provided, another communication was issued on July 22. However, it alleged that no concrete reply had been furnished on the item-wise timelines for completion of pending procurement of medicines, consumables and medical equipment.

The continued failure to comply with the directions had hampered monitoring of critical procurement activities and reflected serious administrative negligence affecting public health ser-

vices, the notice alleged.

The notice asked the Health Secretary to explain why the repeated directions were not followed and why no Action Taken Report or reply was submitted despite repeated reminders.

It also sought an explanation on why disciplinary action under the applicable Conduct Rules should not be recommended against the officers responsible for the alleged omission and dereliction of duty.

According to the notice, the Secretary has been directed to submit a reply along with an Action Taken Report by Wednesday, stating the reasons for the alleged non-compliance and the corrective measures taken to prevent such lapses from recurring.

It said that if no satisfactory reply is received within the stipulated period, disciplinary proceedings may be recommended against the officer or officers concerned under the extant rules.

DU appoints election officers for 2026-27 students' union polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University on Wednesday notified the appointment of the chief election officer and the chief returning officer for the upcoming students' union elections, expected to take place in September.

The notification mentioned that Raj Kishore Sharma from the Department of Chemistry has been appointed as the Chief Election Officer (CEO) and Rajesh Singh, the University Librarian, as the Chief Returning Officer (CRO) for the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections for the 2026-27 academic session.

The Vice-Chancellor, in his capacity as the Patron of DUSU, under Clause 16 of the Delhi University Students' Union Constitution, had made the appointments, the notification noted.

The appointments will come into effect immediately and remain in force until further orders.

The appointments mark the beginning of the process for the annual DUSU elections, which are among the



RAJ KISHORE SHARMA FROM THE DEPARTMENT OF CHEMISTRY HAS BEEN APPOINTED AS THE CHIEF ELECTION OFFICER (CEO)

country's most closely watched student body polls and witness contests between major student organisations, including the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), the National Students' Union of India (NSUI), the Students' Federation of India (SFI) and the All India Students' Association (AISA).

The notification, signed by the registrar, further added, "The Vice-Chancellor has also appointed the Principals of the Colleges and Heads of the Institutions affiliated to Delhi University Students' Union as Election Officers for the conduct of Election of Office Bearers and Members of the Central Council of Delhi University Students' Union in their respective Colleges and Institutions for the year 2026-27."

The university is expected to announce the detailed election schedule, including dates for filing nominations, withdrawal of candidature, polling and counting, in due course.

Delhi Police holds interstate coordination meet to bolster security

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police on Wednesday held an interstate coordination meeting with senior police officers from 11 States and Union Territories to finalise a joint security strategy and strengthen intelligence sharing ahead of Independence Day celebrations.

The meeting chaired by Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar was attended by senior police officers from Haryana, Punjab, Uttar

Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Uttarakhand, Bihar, Rajasthan, Jammu and Kashmir, and Chandigarh. Senior officers from the central intelligence and enforcement agencies also took part in the meeting held at the Delhi Police headquarters.

The meeting focused on ensuring incident-free Independence Day celebrations through enhanced coordination among law enforcement agencies, officials said.

"The meeting was attended by special commissioners



of police heading the Law and Order, Special Cell, Traffic, Protective Security Division, Crime, Transport and Intelligence units, besides other senior officers," a senior police official said.

During the meeting, officers shared intelligence inputs

and reviewed anti-terror measures, including strengthening border checks, verification of suspicious persons and preventive security measures.

Discussions also covered monitoring and regulation of paragliders, drones and other flying objects in open areas as part of the security arrangements, the officials said. The participating officers stressed the need for timely sharing of advance intelligence on the movement of suspicious persons and vehicles. They also discussed enhanced monitor-

ing of social media, action against interstate criminal gangs operating in the National Capital Region (NCR), and measures to curb the illegal supply of firearms and narcotics.

Traffic management plans and restrictions during the Independence Day celebrations were also reviewed. The officers discussed measures to prevent unauthorised intrusion through interstate borders and agreed to maintain close coordination for the effective implementation of security arrangements.

Yamuna shows marginal decrease in faecal coliform levels in July: DPCC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) data on Yamuna water quality for July shows a decrease in faecal coliform levels at several points along the river as compared to the previous month, indicating a declined amount of untreated sewage in the river.

The report, however, continues to show high levels of Biological Oxygen Demand (BOD), a measure of the amount of dissolved oxygen required by microorganisms

to break down organic matter in water. Higher BOD value indicates higher levels of pollution, often leading to oxygen depletion and causing harm to aquatic life.

Yamuna water quality testing by the DPCC involves collecting samples from at least seven locations along the course of the river in the capital, gauging several parameters such as BOD, dissolved oxygen, chemical oxygen demand, pH and faecal coliform content, to determine pollution levels.

These locations are Palla, Wazirabad, ISBT bridge, ITO



bridge, Nizamuddin bridge, Okhla barrage and Asgarpur in Kidwali, Haryana.

While only one point showed slight deterioration

in faecal coliform levels since June, other four points showed considerable improvement, and two points showed no change.

However, the readings remained much higher than the permissible limit of 2,500 and the desirable level of 500.

The June report showed slight deterioration at Nizamuddin Bridge, as levels of faecal coliform remained as high as 130,000 Most Probable Number per 100 millilitres (MPN/100 ml), as compared to 120,000 MPN/100 ml in June. The river showed improvement at Asgarpur, where levels of faecal coliform remained at 320,000 (MPN/100 ml) in July, an improvement from 390,000 in June.

MCD rolls out New York-style hygiene rating system for Delhi restaurants

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Diners in Delhi will soon be able to judge a restaurant's hygiene standards before stepping inside, with the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) introducing a public grading system under which eateries will be assigned ratings from 'A' to 'D' based on kitchen cleanliness, food handling, pest control, waste disposal and staff hygiene.

Modelled on New York City's health grading system, the mechanism was introduced last month as part of the MCD's first comprehensive revision of operational guidelines for eating establishments, replacing inspection practices that had largely remained unchanged since

1964. Every establishment will begin with a score of 100 during inspections. One point will be deducted for every minor violation, four points for every major violation, and 10 points for every critical violation before a final hygiene grade is assigned.

As per the guidelines, establishments scoring between 90 and 100 will receive Grade 'A', those scoring between 75 and 89 Grade 'B', between 60 and 74 Grade 'C', while those scoring below 60 will receive Grade 'D'. Any establishment recording two or more critical violations will automatically receive Grade 'D' regardless of its final score.

"The grading system is meant to improve transparency. Customers will know how an establishment

performed during inspection, while businesses maintaining higher standards will also benefit," a senior MCD official said.

The Hygiene Rating Certificate will have to be displayed prominently at the entrance of every establishment, with failure to do so itself amounting to a violation of licence conditions. The inspections themselves are also being revised.

Officials said that instead of brief, largely uniform inspections focused on documentation, inspectors will now examine a detailed set of food safety and hygiene parameters, including food preparation and storage, kitchen sanitation, cleanliness of utensils and equipment, hand hygiene of food handlers, pest-control measures,



waste segregation, ventilation, first-aid facilities and the overall health of kitchen staff.

Food handlers will be required to wear clean uniforms and head coverings, maintain proper hand hygiene, avoid jewellery while preparing food and stay away from food prepara-

tion if suffering from fever, diarrhoea or skin infections. Establishments must also maintain written standard operating procedures for food preparation, cleaning and waste disposal.

"Earlier, inspections were largely uniform and could often be completed within a

few minutes. Now, inspections will follow a standardised checklist and can take close to an hour depending on the category of the establishment. The emphasis is on assessing actual public health risks rather than merely checking documents," the official said.

The MCD has also introduced a risk-based inspection system under which food establishments will be classified as high, medium or low risk based on seating capacity, nature of operations, compliance history, complaints received and previous enforcement action.

Large banquet halls, food courts and establishments with a history of serious violations will face more frequent inspections, while low-risk establishments such as

small eateries and takeaway outlets with a clean compliance record will largely be inspected annually or in response to complaints.

"A small takeaway outlet and a banquet hall serving hundreds of people every day cannot be regulated in the same manner. The inspection schedule will now be linked to the risk profile instead of following a one-size-fits-all approach," the official said, adding that surprise inspections could still be carried out wherever there was credible information or an imminent public health concern.

The guidelines classify food businesses into seven categories, including restaurants and banquet halls, cloud kitchens, takeaway outlets, dhabas, catering units, food

courts and terrace dining facilities, with separate operational requirements for each.

Meanwhile, members of restaurant associations said that establishments under the organised sector already follow stringent hygiene standards but welcomed efforts to create a more uniform inspection framework.

"In the organised sector, hygiene and public health are taken extremely seriously, and nobody compromises on that. At the moment, everything is in a transition phase after the de-linking of the Health Trade Licence and the move towards certification through FSSAI," said Sandeep Anand Goyle, Delhi chapter head of the National Restaurant Association of India.

IN FOCUS



Students in traditional attire celebrate during Teej festival, at Shahzada Nand College in Amritsar, Punjab

PTI

Delhi CM holds public hearing at Jan Seva Sadan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday held a public hearing at Jan Seva Sadan where she heard grievances from citizens across the Capital on issues ranging from pensions, education, and healthcare to property matters and scheme regularisation. The Chief Minister directed officials of concerned departments to resolve all cases on priority in a time-bound manner.

A large number of women also met the Chief Minister during the hearing, expressing gratitude for the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana, which was approved by the Cabinet on July 28 and whose online portal opened on August 1.

The women described the scheme as a landmark initiative for economic empowerment, saying it has created new hope by placing women's dignity, self-reliance, and financial security at the forefront.

The Chief Minister thanked them and said the Government is fully



committed to the holistic development of women and to making them self-reliant.

On pensions, the Chief Minister took serious note of complaints received during the hearing and separately instructed officials to examine each case individually and ensure that all eligible beneficiaries receive pension benefits within the stipulated timeframe. Pension-related grievances have historically been among the most

common categories at public hearings, often involving elderly citizens whose applications have been pending for extended periods due to documentation gaps or administrative delays.

The hearing covered property-related matters, Ayushman Bharat scheme access, and regularisation issues alongside the pension and welfare scheme complaints.

After reviewing each case, the Chief Minister directed concerned

officials to take prompt action and ensure every eligible citizen receives the benefits of Government welfare schemes.

CM said the public hearing is not merely a platform for addressing complaints but a means of strengthening public trust and reinforcing the Government's commitment to good governance. She said the Government's objective is to ensure that every citizen's grievance is heard with sensitivity, transparency, and within a defined timeframe.

The Jan Seva Sadan public hearing is a regular mechanism the Delhi Government uses for direct citizen access to the Chief Minister's office. The format, where citizens bring their complaints directly to a venue where senior officials are also present, allows for immediate direction to be issued to the relevant department rather than requiring citizens to navigate the complaint system independently after the hearing. The presence of women specifically coming to thank the Chief Minister for the

Delhi Lakshmi Yojana at a public hearing held just five days after the portal opened is a visible indicator of the scheme's resonance among its intended beneficiaries.

The portal opened on August 1 with the Chief Minister personally registering the first applicants at a programme in Geeta Colony. The Government has set a target of releasing the first instalment to eligible women by Raksha Bandhan, which falls later this month, creating a tight operational window for application processing, eligibility verification, and disbursement.

The range of issues raised at Wednesday's hearing reflects the breadth of grievances that accumulate in a city of Delhi's size and complexity. Property regularisation, scheme access, and pension delays are structural problems that require sustained administrative attention beyond what a single public hearing can resolve, which is why the Chief Minister's direction to officials to ensure time-bound resolution of each case.

LS official found dead at Noida flat; suicide note mentions ₹70 lakh loan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 40-year-old officer posted as Joint Director in the Lok Sabha's reporting branch was found dead at his flat in Kendriya Vihar-II in Gautam Buddha Nagar's Noida Phase 2 on Sunday. According to police officials, a suicide note was also recovered from the premises that mentions a loan of approximately ₹70 lakh.

The deceased has been identified as Gaurav Gautam. The Noida Phase 2 police received information through a hospital memo on August 2 that a 40-year-old man had been brought for treatment and declared dead, with doctors



stating he had died by suicide. A Field Unit and forensics team were dispatched to the scene.

"The body was sent for a post-mortem examination after inquest

proceedings. Further legal action is underway," police said.

The circumstances in which Gautam was found paint a picture of a Sunday that began ordinarily and ended in tragedy. His wife was not at the flat when he died. When she returned and found the door unanswered despite calling and knocking, she contacted a security guard for assistance.

Together they entered the flat and found Gautam unresponsive. He was taken to hospital, where he was declared dead on arrival.

A police officer confirmed that the ID produced by the family shows his designation as Joint Director, Lok Sabha, Parliament of India. He was serving in the report-

ing branch of the lower house, which handles the transcription and documentation of parliamentary proceedings, one of the most precise and demanding administrative functions within Parliament's secretariat.

The suicide note recovered from the flat specifically references a loan of around ₹70 lakh. Police said the contents of the note are being examined in detail. Whether the loan was from a bank, a private lender, or individuals, and whether there were specific pressures linked to its repayment, are among the questions investigators are trying to establish from the note and from interviews with family members. A ₹70 lakh debt is a sub-

stantial financial burden for a Government servant, even a senior one at the Joint Director level.

While Joint Directors in Parliament's secretariat are senior officers who draw salaries commensurate with their seniority, a loan of this magnitude can create repayment pressures that accumulate over time, particularly if the loan was taken at high interest or from multiple sources simultaneously.

The investigation will attempt to establish the full picture of Gautam's financial situation, including whether there were demands for repayment that had intensified in the period before his death. Kendriya Vihar-II in Noida is a residential colony largely

inhabited by central Government employees, its name reflecting its character as a Government housing complex.

Parliament's secretariat is among the more insulated and stable employers in the central Government establishment, with defined career paths and service protections. That a Joint Director in this service was carrying a burden large enough to end his life raises questions about the informal financial systems, including informal lending and borrowing that can develop within even stable employment communities, and about the support mechanisms available to officers under financial stress.

Mumbai Police invoke MCOCA against Z gang

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

The Crime Branch of Mumbai Police has invoked the stringent Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA) against 12 members of the "Z Gang" including its'kingpin' Zulfikar Behlim for allegedly running an organised extortion racket.

The gang allegedly operated on the lines of the infamous D-Gang of Dawood Ibrahim and extorted money from businessmen, contractors and residents in the western suburbs, officials said.

The gang members allegedly threatened victims with firearms, physically assaulted them and issued death threats, they said. All 12 members have been arrested.

Behlim and his associates had multiple serious criminal cases registered against them at various police stations in the western suburbs, including offences related to extortion, criminal intimidation, assault and illegal use of weapons.

Following a detailed probe



and after obtaining approval from the Joint Commissioner of Police (Crime), the Crime Branch Unit 9 invoked provisions of the MCOCA against Zulfikar Behlim, his brother Mohsin Behlim, and 10 others on August 4, officials said. Police sources described the

action as a significant blow to organised crime. Further investigations are underway to trace the gang's financial transactions, its wider network of associates and uncover other criminal activities linked to the syndicate, police added.

Air India's flight faced turbulence for five minutes; crew suffered spinal, neck injuries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Air India's flight from Phuket to Delhi on Tuesday experienced turbulence for four to five minutes and some crew members suffered spinal and neck injuries, according to Civil Aviation Minister K Ramamohan Naidu. At least 17 people, including 4 cabin crew members, suffered injuries due to the mid-air turbulence and the aircraft suddenly lost 300 feet in altitude.

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) is probing the incident. At a briefing in the National Capital on Wednesday, Naidu said the aircraft experienced mid-air turbulence for five minutes. There was turbulence for four to five minutes, he added.

"The plane had to travel for one more hour and even through that hour, the crew members provided all the assistance required. It was very brave... I would like to thank them for the bravery they have shown," he said.

When asked about the extent of injuries, the minister said that a couple of crew members have spinal injuries near the tailbone and also near the neck, adding that doctors have advised them to rest. There were 137 passengers and 8 crew members onboard the plane. A total of 13 passengers and 4 crew members were admitted to hospital for treatment of their injuries on Tuesday. "As of 15:30 hrs on August



5, all 13 passengers who were admitted to hospital following the incident involving Air India flight AI2379 from Phuket to Delhi on August 4 have been discharged. "Four crew members remain under medical care and continue to receive treatment," the airline said in a statement.

The airline also said its teams remain present at the hospitals and are in close contact with those affected. "Air India A320 aircraft VT-EXO operating flight AI2379 (Phuket-Delhi) experienced loss of approximately 300 feet in altitude during the flight. "Pilot in Command reported a severe injury to one cabin crew member, injury to another and minor injuries to a few passengers due to a sudden loss of approximately 300 feet in altitude," a senior DGCA official said on Tuesday.

Govt secures Meta apology after PM video...

Government sources said the discussion included the temporary restriction of the PM's post, CSAM on Meta platforms, the spread of deepfake content and how content recommendation systems work.

Meta representatives also admitted to spending heavily to promote some content and expressed regret for these errors.

The controversy centres on a video message the PM posted on July 23, 2026. In a address to students, PM Modi spoke about the distress caused by exam paper leaks, especially in the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate). He spoke of Government actions and announced plans for tougher laws, fast-track courts and stricter penalties for those involved. The message was posted two days after police action on students who had been protesting at Jantar Mantar since June 6. On July 28, the Facebook version of the post was briefly unavailable to users in India, from 12.30 am to 5.00 am. The video remained accessible outside India and was quickly restored once the problem was found. Meta said the incident was a technical error and apologised for the temporary restriction.

MeitY was not satisfied with Meta's explanation and called senior Meta officials, including those responsible for global public policy, for further talks. Government sources said that if the removal was a technical failure, a company as large as Meta should have systems to prevent such incidents, especially with important official content.

On August 3, the Parliamentary Standing Committee met to discuss how to regulate social and digital platforms.

Representatives from Meta (including Facebook, Instagram, and WhatsApp), Google, YouTube, X and Snapchat attended the meeting, along with senior officials from the MeitY and the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA). Meta representatives said they regretted the incident, called it an algorithmic or operational

error, and said they were willing to apologise and take steps to prevent it from happening again.

Top IAS duo get extensions

The rules have a provision to extend the services of the defence secretary, foreign secretary, home secretary, director of the Intelligence Bureau, secretary of the Research and Analysis Wing, and a few others beyond the retirement age of 60 years.

Mohan, a 1989-batch IAS officer of Sikkim cadre, was appointed Home Secretary in August 2024.

CBI brings back UAE fugitive in ₹88-crore...

The case began with a complaint filed in April 2023 at Chatushrungi police station in Pune. As the Economic Offences Wing (EOW) of Pune Police investigated, they found the alleged fraud affected hundreds of depositors, with losses estimated at ₹88 crore. Even though formal investment agreements were made, the promised returns and principal were not paid back.

Vishakha Rathod left after the investigation started. In April 2024, authorities issued a Look Out Circular for the couple. The Maharashtra Protection of Interest of Depositors (MPID) Court then issued arrest warrants and a public notice. On June 4, 2026, Interpol Red Notices were issued for both, allowing global tracking.

Avinash Rathod was detained in the UAE and sent back to India on July 23. He was arrested at Mumbai International Airport by the Pune EOW and later placed in police custody. With Vishakha Rathod's deportation soon after, both main accused have now been brought back within a short period.

The CBI, acting as India's National Central Bureau for Interpol, worked with Emirati law enforcement, the MEA, and the MHA to locate

FROM PAGE - 1

and bring back the accused. The investigation is ongoing in Pune, where both accused are now in the custody of Maharashtra Police. Authorities are tracing the money, looking into the involvement of associates and assessing the total losses to investors.

Jantar Mantar protest targeted in alleged...

The police further claim, the suspects aimed to attack security personnel and protesters, hoping to turn the student protest into a larger security or communal issue. Their plan failed because of increased police presence.

They returned to Punjab, where they were caught in a joint intelligence operation. Police recovered three illegal pistols, nine live cartridges, four petrol bombs, and a stolen motorcycle from the suspects.

In another operation, West Bengal's Special Task Force arrested Mohammad Hamim Mondal in Purba Bardhaman on the night of July 30-31. Mondal, who lives in Renaissance Township, is suspected of links to Jaish-e-Mohammed. Investigators allege that handlers in Pakistan told him to get a police uniform, join the CJP protest at Jantar Mantar, and try to cause unrest. Mondal was also said to be watching the movements of West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari and other top officials, looking for areas with less security.

His associate, Arpita Sarkar, was arrested on July 31 in Sahibganj, Jharkhand, for helping gather intelligence and run honey trap operations. Both have been charged under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act.

Both groups allegedly followed orders from across the border, used encrypted apps and social media to plan and recruit, and deliberately chose a long-running, high-profile protest in central Delhi. It is not new for Pakistan's intelligence agencies and related groups to try to exploit divisions in India, but recent events show they are speeding up their recruitment methods.

The fact that two different groups targeted the same protest at the same time, one led by ISI oper-

atives in Punjab and the other linked to JeM in Bengal, shows this was coordinated and not a coincidence. This suggests that protest schedules are being closely watched, with a focus on high-profile, easy-to-access events that can be used to make unrest appear spontaneous, sources said.

Investigations are still looking into how much local help there was in Delhi, how large these networks are, and whether there is deeper infiltration.

Algorithms under scanner

For a brief period, users in India saw messages about a legal request or warnings about harmful AI-generated content, even though the original post was an official address. Meta put the video back up and said the removal was not intentional. Still, the government and the panel were not satisfied with this answer. They asked for a complete technical audit trail from when the problem was first noticed or reported until the video was restored.

Let's look at how these algorithms work. For people across India, the information we see is selected for us, not random.

The algorithm is not neutral. Every morning, millions in Delhi check Instagram, X, and YouTube for updates. But what if what we see is not the most popular, but what the platform wants us to see? Social media algorithms are designed to keep us engaged, but more people are starting to worry that these systems can be influenced. ced.

Platforms can quietly boost some creators, political opinions, or topics while making others harder to find, and users often do not realise this is happening. This can happen in several ways. For example, a post might be shown to more people in its first hour so it becomes popular quickly. Certain keywords or hashtags might be hidden during protests or elections. Links to competing apps or critical news sites might spread more slowly.

To users, everything still seems normal. It appears that the algorithm is making the deci-

sions. But these decisions have real effects. In a country as diverse as India, a biased feed can shape how people think about topics like NEET reforms or Jammu and Kashmir. Talented creators might be overlooked, and smaller voices can be drowned out. As a result, people may not get the full picture of what's happening around them. India's IT Rules already require platforms to be more open about removing content and moderating posts.

But the bigger issue is how content is ranked. So how does your feed decide what appears first? Experts say the key is to be digitally aware and look for different viewpoints.

This is why, during the August 3 meeting of the Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology, lawmakers questioned Meta representatives about possible bias in their algorithms. They wanted to know why harmful content, such as material about the sexual exploitation of women or children, often remains online. Meanwhile, an official message from the Prime Minister was blocked for hours.

Lawmakers also questioned how well the algorithms can detect deepfakes, especially those involving the Prime Minister and other important figures. They pointed out that fake videos spread widely during recent student protests. They also asked who approved or oversaw the automated decision, whether a human review was done for verified high-profile accounts, and how the algorithm promotes content.

Parties such as the BJP, Congress, Samajwadi Party, and Aam Aadmi Party reached about 23 million people. Meanwhile, some new or unregistered groups linked to protests or special causes received even more promotion, with some reaching 27 million, and one new anti-reservation forum reaching seven million.

Chairman Nishi Kant Dubey suggested this means the platform's rules might favour newer or more provocative content over established voices, which could impact public order and democracy. Meta said it is willing to review and change its algorithms and will share details with the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA).

Jharkhand job exam row: students expand stir, CM offers talks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

Students and job aspirants intensified their protest over alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations in Jharkhand with five demonstrators joining an indefinite hunger strike, even as Chief Minister Hemant Soren said the question paper leak issues are a national problem and offered talks to resolve the impasse.

The protest, which began on July 25 under the banner of the JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch at Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium here, emerged as one of the biggest student-led movements in the state in recent years.

The demonstrators are demanding cancellation of the 14th Jharkhand PSC Civil Services Examination and an independent probe into the alleged irregularities in the recruitment test either by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) or by a panel of retired high court judges from

outside Jharkhand. They also stressed comprehensive reforms in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC).

Ahead of the monsoon session of the State Assembly, set to begin on Thursday, five protesters, including two women, joined Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha (JLKM) leader Devendra Nath Mahto, who has been on a hunger strike for the past four days.

Mahto's health became a matter of concern after his blood sugar and blood pressure levels dropped significantly.

Social activist Sonam Wangchuk, who recently observed a 26-day hunger strike in Delhi over the NEET paper leak issue, spoke to Mahto over the phone and urged him to at least drink water to safeguard his health. Following Wangchuk's appeal, Mahto agreed to end his complete fast by drinking water



while continuing his indefinite protest.

The protesters said they had been forced to adopt the extreme form of agitation after repeated appeals to the Government failed to produce any concrete action.

"Our five friends, including two women, have joined the hunger strike to strengthen the move-

ment and press for our demands," said JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch spokesperson Jivan Kumar. One of the fasting protesters, Sabita Kumari, said the Government had ignored students' concerns, leaving them with no alternative but to intensify their agitation.

Another agitator, Habiba, made an emotional appeal to the CM,

saying, "The chief minister is like our guardian. When children remain hungry, a guardian also feels pain. We hope he will listen to our grievances. We want action and justice, not just assurances."

The protesters also organised a Tiranga Yatra at the protest site to highlight their demands and draw public attention to the alleged recruitment irregularities.

As the agitation gained momentum, the State administration initiated efforts to break the deadlock through dialogue.

Ranchi Sub-Divisional Officer Kumar Rajat and Additional District Magistrate (Law and Order) Dhananjay Kumar visited the protest site and invited a five-member delegation of students for discussions at the Chief Minister's residence.

"The students have sought some time to deliberate on the proposal," the SDO said.

Responding to the growing protests, Soren acknowledged the seriousness of the issue,

describing recruitment paper leaks as "not merely a Jharkhand issue but a major national problem affecting the youth across the country."

In a post on X, Soren said the concerns raised by students were being treated with utmost seriousness by his Government.

He asserted that probe agencies were working round the clock and those responsible for the alleged irregularities were being sent to jail.

"Our objective is not just to investigate but to provide a permanent solution to students' concerns," the chief minister said, adding that the doors of the state Government remained open for the students to present their demands and suggestions.

He assured that every point would be examined carefully and a concrete solution would be announced soon.

Earlier in the day, Soren met Governor Santosh Kumar Gangwar and briefed him on the

ongoing protests as well as the progress of the investigation.

According to a Raj Bhavan statement, the Governor described the alleged recruitment irregularities as a matter of grave concern and stressed that the commissions that conduct competitive exams must function with complete transparency and credibility to maintain public confidence, particularly among the youth.

The CM assured the governor that no injustice would be allowed against students.

The issue also triggered political reactions across party lines.

A BJP delegation led by Leader of Opposition Babulal Marandi visited the protest site and reiterated the party's demand for cancellation of the 14th JPSC examination and a CBI investigation into the alleged irregularities. Marandi alleged that the ongoing CID probe was intended to cover up the issue instead of exposing those responsible.

Parliamentary panel calls for next generation reforms in Panchayati Raj

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government should undertake a comprehensive review of the functioning of Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) and formulate a roadmap for the "next generation of panchayat reforms" to strengthen democratic decentralisation, financial sustainability and citizen participation, a parliamentary committee has recommended.

In a report tabled in Parliament on Wednesday, the Department-related Parliamentary Standing Committee on Rural Development and Panchayati Raj said that while PRIs have emerged as important instruments of democratic decentralisation over the past three decades, several structural challenges continue to persist.



"The Committee are of the considered view that after more than three decades of experience, the time has come to move beyond the mere creation of institutions and focus on strengthening their effectiveness, responsiveness and capacity to deliver sustainable and inclusive development," the report said.

It recommended that the Ministry of Panchayati Raj "undertake a comprehensive review of the functioning of

Panchayati Raj Institutions in consultation with States, experts and other stakeholders and formulate a roadmap for the next generation of panchayat reforms".

The roadmap, it said, should focus on "deepening democratic decentralization, strengthening institutional capacities, enhancing financial sustainability, promoting digital governance and ensuring greater citizen participation".

The panel also recom-

mended institutionalising "robust performance assessment and monitoring mechanisms" and promoting "evidence-based planning and decision-making at the grassroots level through appropriate indices and data-driven frameworks".

The committee also expressed concern that Gram Sabha meetings were losing their vitality.

"The Committee notes with concern... that in many areas Gram Sabha meetings are becoming ceremonial in nature and public participation has declined considerably," it said.

Warning that this would weaken grassroots democracy, the report said, "The Committee are of the view that weakening of Gram Sabhas would adversely affect the spirit of democratic decentralisation envisaged under the Constitution."

PM hails J&K, Ladakh growth post-Article 370 abrogation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday said since the abrogation of Article 370 in 2019, the lives of people in Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh have witnessed wide-ranging transformation, with expansion of infrastructure and growth in opportunities in education, healthcare, entrepreneurship and sports sectors.

On the seventh anniversary of the abrogation of Article 370, Modi said the Centre remains committed to the development of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh and to ensuring that every citizen has the opportunity to "dream big, achieve and contribute" to the making of a Viksit Bharat.

He said infrastructure in the two Union Territories has expanded, while opportunities in areas such as education, healthcare, entrepreneurship and



sports have grown.

Be it women or marginalised communities, those who were denied their basic constitutional rights for decades have been empowered thanks to the full application of the Constitution of India, Modi added.

In a post on social media, the prime minister said, "Seven years ago, on this day, Articles 370 and 35(A) became history, marking a

decisive new chapter in the journey of Jammu and Kashmir as well as Ladakh..."

On August 5, 2019, the BJP-led Centre abrogated Article 370, which gave special status to Jammu and Kashmir, and the erstwhile state was bifurcated into two union territories — Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh.

"We reaffirm our commitment to the progress of

Jammu and Kashmir as well as Ladakh and to ensure that every citizen has the opportunity to dream big, achieve and contribute to the making of a Viksit Bharat," he added.

PM Modi said, "August 5 this year assumes even greater significance as this is the year the nation commemorates the 125th birth anniversary of Syama Prasad Mookerjee".

"His lifelong commitment to national unity continues to inspire generations. What he envisioned decades ago found historic fulfilment on 5th August 2019," he said.

Mookerjee was the founder of Bharatiya Jana Sangh, the precursor of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party. He had fought for full integration of Jammu and Kashmir with the rest of India by scrapping Article 370. Born on July 6, 1901, Mookerjee died under detention on June 23, 1953, in Srinagar.

Union Govt approves key foreign postings to IMF, ADB, ICAO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Wednesday approved key foreign postings, including those in Washington-based International Monetary Fund (IMF) and Asian Development Bank in the Philippines, among others.

Senior bureaucrat Satyajit Mohanty, currently working as Joint Secretary in the Defence Ministry, has been appointed to the post of Representative of India in the Council of International Civil Aviation Organisation (ICAO), Montreal, Canada for three years, a Personnel Ministry order said.

Rahul Jain, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, has been named Senior Adviser to the Executive Director (India),



International Monetary Fund (IMF), Washington DC, USA for a period of three years, it said.

Jain is a 2005-batch Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer of Madhya Pradesh cadre.

Baldeo Purusharth, a 2002-batch IAS officer of Punjab cadre, will be Senior Adviser to the Executive Director, Asian Development Bank, Manila, Philippines, the order said.

He is currently Joint Secretary in the Department



of Economic Affairs. The foreign deputation tenure of Hemang Jani as Senior Adviser to the Executive Director, World Bank, Washington DC, USA has been extended for a further period of two years beyond July 16, 2027 (that is up to July 16, 2029), the order said.

Kapil Patidar, Director in the Department of Economic Affairs, has been appointed as Adviser to the Executive Director (India), IMF, Washington.

West Bengal BJP cracks whip, expels 30 workers over extortion

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Cracking the whip hard on erring party men, the Bengal BJP has expelled at least 30 of its subaltern-level party members and suspended about 250 of them following complaints of extortion against them.

The decision comes days after State party president Samik Bhattacharya and subsequently senior leader and Minister Agnimitra issued strong warnings to the party brass against stepping into the shoes of the Trinamool Congress by taking to corrupt ways that included extortion.

Some inside sources, however, placed the number of expulsions at 22, adding 250 workers at Mandal level had not been suspended but slapped with show-cause notices for their conduct. A senior State leader associat-



Representative image

ed with the party disciplinary committee said that initially 30 workers had been expelled following complaints but later on some of them were taken back as they were found innocent.

"We are firmly walking our talk... Our leadership is very strong about the issue of corruption ... our State president had repeatedly warned

the workers against tolajaji (extortion)... they were asked to mend their ways, failing which they would face the music and now they are facing the music," the leader said, adding the next step could be criminal action.

"The party will keep a close watch on the workers... if they are found guilty, then they could even be criminal-

ly prosecuted," another leader said.

Earlier, Bhattacharya said that the disciplinary committee had found no major complaints against any MLA or MP. "Some workers at the grassroots level have been doing some mischief... we told them that we will not tolerate this... we are not Trinamool Congress," Bhattacharya had

earlier warned, saying "if the party workers continued to follow in the footsteps of the TMC then the future of BJP in Bengal was bleak."

Incidentally, Paul had during a meeting on Monday said that some people were thinking that as they had come to power they could earn money via extortion but warned: "such actions will be dealt with very firmly."

Saying that Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari was following a zero-tolerance policy against corruption, which was why he had started four helpline numbers for the people to register their complaints. "These helpline numbers have been provided against illegal toll tax, illegal syndicates, extortion, and liquor dens. People can call there to lodge complaints," she said, adding the BJP Government would not preach one thing and act in a different manner.

Ex-Ethiopian Airlines chief Tewolde named Air India CEO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Air India on Wednesday appointed former Ethiopian Airlines chief Tewolde Gebremariam as its new CEO and Managing Director to replace Campbell Wilson, marking another change of guard at the airline after the takeover by the Tata Group four years ago. Gebremariam, who will be the second foreign CEO at Air India, will be taking over the reins at a time when the airline is working on its ambitious expansion plans amid multiple external headwinds. Wilson resigned in April this year after overseeing the initial phase of the airline's transformation. The country's two top airlines — Air India and IndiGo — now have foreign CEOs. On August 3, Irish national and former chief of global airlines' grouping IATA, Willie Walsh, took over as IndiGo CEO.

Announcing his appointment, Air India said Gebremariam is widely recognised as one of the most suc-



cessful aviation chief executives. The executive transition marks a pivotal juncture in the airline's transformation journey to become a world-class, leading global airline, the airline said in a release.

"During his decade-plus tenure as CEO of Ethiopian Airlines Group, he spearheaded a multi-billion-dollar expansion, transforming a regional carrier into Africa's largest, most profitable, and decorated airline group — growing revenue by more than fourfold and fleet size nearly threefold," Air India said in a release.

According to the release, his unique strength lies in managing complex operational land-

scapes, driving cultural transformation, building competitive global hubs, and developing world-class MRO (Maintenance, Repair, and Overhaul) and aviation training infrastructure.

Tata Sons and Air India Chairman N Chandrasekaran said that having completed the initial phase of stabilisation, integration, and fleet commitments under Campbell's guidance, the airline is now entering a critical execution and expansion era. "Tewolde's track record in building one of the world's most efficient and profitable airline groups makes him uniquely suited to lead Air India. "His operational

expertise, commitment to safety, and vision for hub development will be instrumental as we establish Air India as a premier global carrier and a source of national pride," he said.

Gebremariam said Air India carries an incredible legacy, and the opportunity to build a world-class global airline that reflects India's extraordinary economic potential is uniquely exciting. The airline's board conducted a comprehensive search to identify the next leader for Air India, overseen by a dedicated Board committee. The committee rigorously evaluated internal as well as highly accomplished external candidates from across the world, according to the release.

His international experience includes serving as Regional Director for India and Southeast Asia based in Mumbai, followed by a stint as Area Manager for Saudi Arabia in Jeddah. When Ethiopian Airlines launched direct flights to the United States, he was

appointed Area Sales Manager for Northeast USA and Canada, based in New York.

His rise within Ethiopian Airlines continued with appointments as Executive Officer for Marketing and Sales in 2004 and Chief Operating Officer in 2006, where he oversaw commercial operations, flight operations, customer services, and maintenance and engineering.

On January 1, 2011, he was elevated to Group Chief Executive Officer, a position from which he built Ethiopian Airlines into Africa's largest and most profitable carrier. Beyond the airline, Gebremariam has held several influential positions in the global aviation ecosystem. He has served on the Board of Governors of the International Air Transport Association (IATA), the executive committee of the African Airlines Association (AFRAA), and the United Nations Secretary-General's High-level Advisory Group on Sustainable Transport.

Zero coal leakage drive: CISF faces hurdles in Jharkhand, West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

A month after the Union Government launched a 'zero coal leakage' drive, the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) flagged several obstructions, including a lack of "timely and adequate" logistical support from coal field managements, manpower shortages and a dearth of necessary funds and legal powers across Jharkhand and West Bengal.

The paramilitary force's field formations have written to the Bharat Coking Coal Limited (BCL), Eastern Coalfields Limited (ECL), Central Coalfields Limited (CCL) and the CISF headquarters in Delhi apprising them of these issues.

Despite these challenges, official sources and documents accessed by PTI state that the central force has



recovered over 6,171 metric tonnes of coal that was either pilfered or stolen, sealed 106 illegal mines and registered 229 FIRs since the drive began a month ago on July 4.

The CISF is entrusted with guarding the country's major coal fields. The Union Government recently authorised the CISF as a designated agency to undertake search and seizure operations under the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957

(MMDR) to check coal theft from the coalfields under its jurisdiction.

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) directed the force to launch a special drive against the coal mafia and criminals to achieve the target of 'zero coal leakage'.

Official sources said the CISF had to delay or postpone raids at a number of places for periods ranging between seven and ten days due to a "lack of timely and adequate logistical support" from the coal field managements.

NC, PDP observe black day on Article 370 anniversary

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

Mainstream political parties, barring the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), on Wednesday observed a 'black day' to mark the seventh anniversary of the abrogation of Article 370 and 35-A in Jammu and Kashmir.

The BJP workers took out a 'Tiranga' rally at several places, maintaining that the abrogation of Articles 370 and 35A on August 5, 2019, marked the beginning of a new era of unity, equality and development for Jammu and Kashmir and fulfilled a long-standing national commitment.

The ruling National Conference party leaders remained at the forefront in staging protest demonstrations in both the capital cities of Jammu and Srinagar.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, who visited flood-hit Poonch to assess damage and relief efforts, once again reiterated his commitment to reversing the Centre's

decisions, saying the ruling National Conference has not accepted the "current circumstances".

His political adversary, Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) Chief and former Chief Minister Mehbooba Mufti, highlighted that no amount of manufactured normalcy or carefully crafted narratives can erase the aspirations of the people of Jammu & Kashmir. Their demand for dignity, justice, and the restoration of 370 remains as strong as ever.

PDP's young turk, Iltija Mufti, also took out a protest march in Srinagar in support of the restoration of the special status of the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir.

Iltija, along with party leaders, including MLA Pulwama Waheed Para, and spokesperson Mohit Bhan, took out the protest march at Sonwar.

Raising slogans demanding the restoration of Article 370, the PDP leaders tried to march towards the Dalgate area, but were stopped by



the police. Speaking to reporters, Iltija said the party will "fight" for the rights "snatched from us seven years ago".

"I want to remind the Prime Minister and the Home Minister that we will fight for it. We want to protest peacefully for it. You are snatching even that right from us. The police here are doing real terror," she said.

Echoing similar sentiments, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, in

a post on X, said, "Seven years, we haven't forgotten, and we haven't reconciled, far less accepted our current circumstances."

My party and I remain committed to reversing all that was done to J-K that took away our rights and threatens our identity, he said.

BJP marked the seventh anniversary of the abrogation of Articles 370 and 35A with celebrations across the Union Territory.

At the party office in Srinagar's Jawahar Nagar area, J-K BJP general secretary (organisation) Ashok Kaul cut a cake to commemorate the occasion.

The party's youth activists had planned a bike rally from Pantha Chowk to the Lal Chowk City centre, but police did not allow them to proceed towards Lal Chowk and diverted them to the party office.

In south Kashmir's Anantnag district, BJP workers took out a Tiranga rally to celebrate. Scores of party workers, carrying the Tricolour and raising patriotic slogans, participated in the procession.

The rally passed through various parts of the town under tight security arrangements.

BJP leader Altaf Thakur said August 5 was a day of celebration as it ended the system of two constitutions and two flags in the country.

To mark the day, the ruling National Conference leaders held a protest in Srinagar, demanding

restoration of the special status of the erstwhile state. Scores of NC leaders, MLAs and workers, led by Minister Sakina Itoo, assembled at the party headquarters, Nawa-i-Subah, and took out a protest march.

Carrying placards in support of Article 370 and the restoration of special status, the protesters tried to take the march out of the party office complex but were stopped by police.

The Congress and the National Conference (NC) held separate protest rallies in Jammu on the seventh anniversary of the abrogation of Article 370, observing it as a "Black Day".

They also demanded the restoration of statehood and constitutional safeguards for land, jobs and other rights.

The police prevented the protest marches towards the city centre, leading to a brief jostling with workers at different locations. We want our statehood back. Our jobs, our land and our rights must be protected. Instead

of listening to our democratic demands, the Government is stopping us from protesting. We are observing a 'Black Day' today. We will continue our agitation until Jammu and Kashmir regains its statehood," a Congress leader told reporters.

In Srinagar, Jammu and Kashmir LG Manoj Sinha dismissed the protests held by NC and PDP for the restoration of special status to the Union territory, saying he "did not see" any demonstrations.

"I did not see any (protest). If I see, I will talk to you (about it)," the LG told a reporter when asked about protests by the National Conference (NC) and the People's Democratic Party (PDP).

Sinha said August 5, 2019, the date marking the abrogation of Articles 370 and 35A, ended the "discriminatory system" in Jammu and Kashmir. "This day, I believe, is also important because it has a great historical significance in ending the discriminatory system," he said.

J&K LG hands over job letters to 37 terror victims' families

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The Lieutenant Governor, Manoj Sinha, on Wednesday handed over appointment letters to 37 Next of Kins (NoKs) of civilians who were brutally killed by terrorists.

He said it is a profound honour to stand with the families of terror victims on this historic day, and it is not merely about appointment letters but it is about remembrance of martyrs, justice to terror victim families, and the reaffirmation of our national will.

"My heartfelt tribute to the innocent civilians martyred by terrorists, and I salute the families who, after decades of anguish and wait, now hold appointment letters that restore dignity and liveli-



hood. Sinha said these appointment letters are not just documents of employment, but they are symbols of social justice, recognition and the nation's solemn promise that its martyrs will never be forgotten, nor their families abandoned.

He also stated that our commitment is reflected in decisive action. After 5th

August 2019, we have dismantled the terror ecosystem to a large extent, strengthened law and order, restored equal rights and created opportunities that allow families to rebuild their lives with confidence.

"The transformation we witness today in Jammu and Kashmir is due to the historic changes of 5th August 2019.

That day marked a constitutional correction and a new beginning for the UT.

Discriminatory barriers were removed, and equal rights were extended to those who were suffering due to discriminatory laws. The principle of one nation, one flag, one constitution was fully implemented and one standard of dignity, justice, and opportunity for all the Indian citizens was upheld," the Lieutenant Governor said, further adding that under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the marginalised groups, tribals, displaced persons from Pok and Chhamb and refugees have received legal rights such as full citizenship, voting rights and ownership rights over property under the Constitution of India.

Row over Mehbooba holding Tricolour upside down

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Former Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister and Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) Chief Mehbooba Mufti has once again sparked a political furore after she was spotted holding the National Flag upside down during a protest in Srinagar on the eve of the seventh anniversary of the Abrogation of Articles 370 and 35-A.

The incident drew sharp criticism from the ruling party, with Union Minister Giriraj Singh calling her a "terrorist".

Hitting back, PDP MLA Waheed Ur Rehman Para on Wednesday termed Union Minister Giriraj Singh's remarks describing former Jammu and Kashmir chief minister Mehbooba Mufti as a "terrorist" as "outrageous" and "irresponsible". In a post on X, Para posted, "Giriraj Singh's remarks calling PDP President Mehbooba Mufti a "terrorist" are outrageous, irresponsible, and



beneath the dignity of a Union Minister. Such language against a former Chief Minister of J&K and a senior Muslim woman leader reflects nothing but prejudice and political intolerance. This is not a political statement; it is a reflection of Giriraj Singh's own

mindset". Singh also claimed that the BJP had tried to reform Mufti during its alliance with the PDP. "Since there was no improvement, we let her go," he said.

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah also reacted cautiously when he was asked to comment on the controversy.

"You have to ask this question from her. It must be a mistake. I cannot believe that a person who served as a CM would deliberately display the flag of the country upside down. I don't think it would have been done deliberately. It must be a mistake."

Interestingly, Chief Spokesman of the Jammu and Kashmir National Conference and a close aide of Omar Abdullah, Tanvir Sadique claimed,

"There are only two possibilities — either Mehbooba Mufti deliberately displayed the national flag upside down, or she did not know the proper protocol despite having served as Chief Minister".

DRI seizes Pak-origin dry dates worth ₹3cr at Kandla Port

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence has seized 364 metric tonnes of Pakistan-origin dry dates worth ₹3 crore in a crackdown on attempts to circumvent India's prohibition on imports originating from the country.

In a statement, the Finance Ministry said the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has unearthed a case involving the clandestine routing and mis-declaration of Pakistan-origin goods through third countries.

In an intelligence-led



operation, officers of DRI intercepted 13 containers carrying 364 metric tonnes (MT) of dry dates, valued at approximately ₹3 crore, imported at Kandla Port. Investigation revealed that the goods, though declared as originating from the UAE, were in fact of Pakistani origin.

The enquiries established that the goods were first transported from Pakistan to Dubai and subsequently shifted to another set of containers before being exported to India.

The importers allegedly suppressed material facts and mis-declared the country of origin in an attempt to evade the prohibition on import of Pakistan-origin goods.

Accordingly, the entire consignment has been seized under the relevant provisions of the Customs Act, 1962.

Last week, DRI officers had uncovered an attempt to import around 14 MTs of Pakistan-origin Guggul resin valued at ₹1.4 crore through misdeclaration of description and country of origin at Tuticorin port.

Datia verdict sparks BJP reset, Tomar apologises

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

In a significant political move following the BJP's defeat in the Datia Assembly bypoll, Madhya Pradesh Assembly Speaker and senior BJP leader Narendra Singh Tomar has publicly apologised to the Kushwaha community, acknowledging that his remarks during the election campaign may have caused hurt and contributed to the party's electoral setback.

Tomar became the first senior BJP leader to express regret after the party's internal assessment reportedly indicated that the influential Kushwaha community, which constitutes around 12 per cent of Datia's electorate, shifted its support towards the Congress, playing a crucial role in the bypoll outcome.

Tomar issued a signed letter addressed to members of the Kushwaha community. In the letter, he said the BJP and the Kushwaha community have always shared a close relationship and stressed that he has consistently respected the community throughout his public life.

He said he never intended to insult anyone and withdrew his earlier remarks, expressing regret if his words had hurt the sentiments of any member of the community.

The controversy stemmed from remarks made by Tomar during the campaign, in which he said the Kushwaha community had a tendency to switch sides, suggesting that its political loyalties often shifted. The statement drew sharp criticism from community leaders, who accused the veteran leader of questioning the community's political integrity and undermining its contribution to the BJP over the years.

The apology comes amid intense introspection within the BJP after the party lost the high-profile Datia bypoll to Congress candidate Kunwar Ghanshyam Singh by a margin of 6,016 votes. Party leaders believe even a limited shift in support among Kushwaha voters may have significantly influenced the result.

Congress leaders have claimed they successfully consolidated support among Other Backward Class communities, particularly the



Kushwahs, through an extensive grassroots campaign led by Satna MLA Siddharth Kushwaha. The party had focused on booth-level outreach while the BJP grappled with internal discontent over ticket distribution and local factionalism.

The Datia defeat has triggered an unusually public review within the BJP. Soon after the results, Chief

Minister Mohan Yadav held a meeting with senior party leaders and campaign managers to assess the reasons behind the loss. The party subsequently dissolved its Datia district unit, constituted review committees and began examining allegations of internal sabotage and organisational lapses that may have contributed to the unexpected defeat.

Maharashtra bans analogue paneer for one year, cites food safety norm violations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Government has imposed a one-year ban on the manufacture and sale of "analogue" or non-dairy paneer in view of public health concerns and widespread violations of food safety norms, officials said on Wednesday.

Offenders could face life imprisonment and a fine of up to ₹10 lakh, as per a recent Government order.

Maharashtra is the second State after Chhattisgarh to impose such a ban.

The Food and Drug Administration (FDA) said it found that several hotels, restaurants, caterers and other food establishments were using analogue paneer in place of conventional paneer without disclosing the substitution on menus, invoices or display boards.

Analogue paneer is a non-dairy substitute made using vegetable oils, starches, emulsifiers and other additives instead of milk fat. It is cheaper to produce than conventional paneer and generally contains lower



protein levels. A gazette notification issued by Maharashtra Food Safety Commissioner Tukaram Mundhe has prohibited the manufacturing, processing, preparation, packing, storage, distribution, wholesale and retail sale, as well as offering for sale, of analogue paneer across the State.

An FDA official said that the Food Safety and Standards Act permits such prohibitory orders for a maximum period of one year.

"The law itself has a provision of banning such items for one year only. As per our information, analogue paneer has very low nutri-

tional value. But there is no legal support for us to put a complete ban on such types of paneer," the official said.

The FDA has warned that serving analogue paneer as conventional dairy paneer without informing consumers would amount to an unfair trade practice under the Food Safety and Standards Act and attract penal action.

Depending on the extent of harm caused, offenders could face imprisonment -- from six months with a fine of ₹1 lakh to life imprisonment and a minimum fine of ₹10 lakh in cases where consumption of unsafe food results in death, the FDA said.

Dhaka slams Hasina's Delhi address

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Bangladesh Ministry of Foreign Affairs issued a strongly worded statement on Tuesday expressing outrage over an evening media interaction held by former Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina in New Delhi.

The ministry described Hasina as an "absconding convicted genocider" and said she and her associates used the event to launch "venomous vitriol against the State of Bangladesh and her people."

The statement said Dhaka had earlier conveyed concerns to the Government of India about the potential impact of such an event on bilateral relations, yet the interaction was allowed to proceed. Officials called the development "deeply regret-

table."

Coming on the second anniversary of the July Revolution, the ministry said Hasina's appearance on Indian soil constituted "an affront to the sovereignty of Bangladesh and a grievous insult to the martyrs of the July Revolution." It rejected what it termed her denial of facts established by the United Nations regarding the killing of civilians, including minor children, during July-August 2024 under the previous government.

"The people of Bangladesh had already rejected such heinous attempts in the past and continue to do so now," the statement said. It added that Bangladeshis remain resolved never to return to "the dark days of fascism" and that the country "will never be a client State." Convicted figures associated with the former regime, it declared,

"will never have a place in the polity of Bangladesh."

The ministry reiterated Bangladesh's desire for a constructive, mutually beneficial relationship with India founded on sovereign equality, mutual respect, non-interference, and national dignity. It noted, however, that repeated requests for Hasina's extradition under the 2013 Bangladesh-India Extradition Treaty have so far received no response.

Allowing her to interact openly with the media, the statement said, is "deeply hurtful to our people's sentiment and detrimental to the development of harmonious bilateral relations."

The press release underscores ongoing tensions between Dhaka and New Delhi over the status of the former prime minister, who remains in India following the events of 2024.

13,092 schools selected as PM SHRI schools across States, UTs: Government

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government on Wednesday told the Rajya Sabha that 13,092 schools have been selected as PM SHRI schools across the states and Union Territories.

In a written response in the Upper House, Minister of State for Education Jayant Chaudhary said the centrally sponsored PM SHRI scheme was approved by the Cabinet in 2022 and fund allocation, release and utilisation began in 2023-24.

"Under the PM SHRI scheme, as of now, a total of 13,092 schools have been selected as PM SHRI schools across the States/UTs including KVS/ NVS/ NCERT," the minister said.

The state and UT-wise



number of PM SHRI schools selected includes 1,888 in Uttar Pradesh, 982 in Andhra Pradesh, 946 in Maharashtra, 944 in Madhya Pradesh, 904 in Bihar, 840 in Odisha and 832 in Telangana.

Karnataka has 660 PM SHRI schools, according to the response.

As informed by the state Government of Karnataka,

the district-wise details of funds allocated, released and utilised in various districts under the PM SHRI scheme during financial year (FY) 2023-24, FY 2024-25 and FY 2025-26 were also provided in the response.

During FY 2023-24, the approved project approval board (PAB) outlay of various districts of Karnataka was

₹5,023.46 lakh, funds released were ₹2,350.72 lakh and expenditure was Rs 991.42 lakh.

During FY 2024-25, the approved PAB outlay was ₹24,593.09 lakh, funds released were ₹1,856.32 lakh and expenditure was ₹1,102.01 lakh. During FY 2025-26, the approved PAB outlay was ₹26,902.07 lakh, funds released were ₹20,726.84 lakh and expenditure was ₹13,245.57 lakh.

The PM SHRI (Pradhan Mantri Schools for Rising India) scheme is a centrally sponsored initiative launched on September 7, 2022, to upgrade over 14,500 existing Government schools into model institutions that showcase the implementation of the National Education Policy (NEP), 2020.

Opposition march in Parliament over police action on students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Opposition MPs took out a protest march in Parliament House complex on Wednesday, demanding Home Minister Amit Shah's statement on alleged police excesses against students, discussion on "misappropriation" of Ram temple donations and statehood for Jammu and Kashmir.

Carrying placards and raising slogans against the Government, the Opposition MPs, including Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, marched from the statue of Mahatma Gandhi at Prerna Shal to Makar Dwar.

Kharge demanded accountability from the Government. Taking a swipe at Shah, Kharge asked why he hasn't been coming to the House.

"They are disrespecting Parliament. It has been so many days but they don't want to step inside the House. What is the issue in coming to the House and



giving a statement?" Kharge told reporters.

Later, in a post on social media, Kharge said, "INDIA demands answers - Why is the Home Minister shying away from making a statement in the Parliament on the atrocities perpetrated against our youth? Isn't the PM responsible for 'chanda-chadhawa chori' in Shree Ram Mandir."

Gandhi also slammed Shah and sought answers over the alleged police brutality against students during the July 20 protest over the paper leak issue. "Amit Shah ji, do not hide; answer the nation's question in Parliament - who ordered the attack on the

students?" Gandhi said in his Facebook post.

The MPs carried placards slamming the Government and demanded a statement by Shah in both Houses of Parliament on the alleged "atrocities" committed by police and other forces on students during protests over the paper leak issue last month.

Several MPs also raised the issue of "misappropriation" of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya. Many MPs, including those from Jammu and Kashmir, carried placards, demanding statehood for Jammu and Kashmir. Wednesday marks the seventh anniversary of the

abrogation of Article 370 and J-K being turned into a Union Territory.

The MPs raised slogans such as 'chhanda chor, gaddi chor', 'Amit Shah jawaab do' and 'chanda chor kahan milenge, BJP ke daftar mein'.

The MPs also kept donation boxes in front of Makar Dwar steps to symbolise the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple and lined up around them to raise slogans against the Government. Some MPs also put cash in the box to symbolise the donations made and "theft" that took place later.

Besides Kharge, Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi, SP's Dimple Yadav and Dharmendra Yadav, TMC's Sagarika Ghose and Mahua Moitra, NCP (SP) Supriya Sule, JMM's Mahua Maji, RSP's NK Premchandran, among others, participated in the protest.

While marching, the protesting MPs lined up behind a big banner that read 'Amit Shah jawaab do'.

Priyanka Gandhi also lashed out at the Government and sought accountability over the alleged police excesses against students.

BJP slams Rahul Gandhi, calls him immature

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Wednesday criticised Rahul Gandhi, saying he is an "immature and part-time" Leader of the Opposition (LoP) who is disrupting Parliament because he is "scared" of a comparison between the Narendra Modi Government's performance and that of the previous Congress-led UPA dispensation.

The ruling party also accused the Congress leader of making "baseless" remarks against the BJP and the RSS, adopting "double standards" on examination paper leaks and running away from debates in Parliament.

The remarks came after Gandhi on Tuesday said the students of the country are in "severe pain" and they do not need Prime Minister Narendra Modi's forgiveness but his apology for his Government's action against them.

Speaking at the launch of a book by former MP Vaiko, the Leader of the Opposition had said students are on the streets because of the RSS' attempts to rewrite the country's history, adding that India will not tolerate its history being trampled upon



by anybody. Gandhi said every state has the right to be treated fairly and express its own culture and language, but the RSS wants only the history subscribed to by it to be followed.

Addressing a press conference here, BJP national spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia alleged that Gandhi is an "immature", "part-time" and "irresponsible" Leader of the Opposition and is preventing Parliament from functioning because he fears the Modi Government's record will expose the Congress.

"Rahul Gandhi is scared. He knows that the characterless Congress will be exposed when there will be comparison of an effective Modi Government and the spineless Congress-led

Government from 2004 to 2014. Therefore, the obstruction," Bhatia said.

Hitting back at Gandhi's remarks against the BJP and the RSS, Bhatia alleged that the Congress leader suffers from "Modi phobia" and "RSS phobia" and is repeatedly describing the Sangh's ideology as "poisonous" without any evidence. "Rahul Gandhi has Modi phobia and RSS phobia... Calling an ideology which has served the nation with utmost sincerity 'poisonous' is very easy, but to prove your point is difficult when you do not have any evidence," he said.

Referring to Gandhi's remarks on students and examination reforms, Bhatia alleged that the Congress leader is adopting "double

standards" by remaining silent on alleged paper leak cases in Opposition-ruled States and claimed the Modi Government has strengthened the legal framework to curb such offences.

"Jharkhand paper leak — Rahul Gandhi is missing. Karnataka paper leak — Rahul Gandhi is missing. Kerala paper leak — Rahul Gandhi is missing. What is this double standard of Rahul Gandhi? What is this hypocrisy?" he said.

Bhatia also alleged that Gandhi fails to substantiate allegations made by him in Parliament despite being directed by the Speaker to authenticate his claims.

Replying to a question on the disruptions in Parliament, Bhatia alleged that Gandhi is "running away" from the House because he is unable to counter the Government's arguments during debates.

"When Parliament is in session, should not the Leader of the Opposition come to the floor of the House with preparation? Rahul Gandhi is also a fugitive from Parliament because he runs away from the House. When Prime Minister Modi, Rajnath Singh and Amit Shah present facts, Rahul Gandhi is left with no answers," he said.

Assam flood damage enormous, normalcy will take time: Nadda

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Union Health Minister JP Nadda on Wednesday visited flood-ravaged areas of Assam and said the scale of devastation was so enormous that it will take time to restore normalcy. Nadda, accompanied by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, toured Sivasagar district's Nepalikhuti area along the Assam-Nagaland border, one of the worst-hit regions in the latest wave of floods that struck on July 19.

"I have visited the flood-hit Nepalikhuti area. Along with CM Sarma, I have witnessed the scale of devastation. The damage is so huge that it will take time (for normalcy to return)," Nadda told reporters after interacting with the affected families. Assuring the affected people of all possible assistance from the Centre, he said the Government stood firmly with them.

"I want to assure you on behalf of Prime Minister Narendra Modi that



Union Minister JP Nadda and Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma visiting flood-hit areas in Upper Assam on Wednesday

there will be no shortcoming from the Indian Government. Whether it is financial assistance, rehabilitation, compensation or support for property losses, everything will be provided," he said.

The visit comes as the Northeastern

state continues to grapple with a severe flood situation. The death toll has risen to 89, while more than 1.22 lakh people remain affected across five districts amid fears of fresh inundation following overnight rains. Nadda travelled to the flood-hit

area in a tractor-trailer along with Sarma as roads remained inaccessible to regular vehicles due to thick layers of mud and silt, 18 days after the deluge struck the region.

"The river flowing down from Mon district (in Nagaland) has devastated village after village. There has been extensive loss of lives and property," the Union minister said. He said PM Modi had deputed him to assess the ground situation and that he had discussed the impact of the floods in detail with the chief minister.

"We will hold a review meeting in the evening to discuss the way forward. CM Sarma did everything possible to provide immediate relief to the affected people, and the relief operations are continuing on a large scale," Nadda said.

He said that while the Assam Government was deploying all its resources to tackle the crisis, the Centre would extend every possible assistance.

BJP demands resignation of re-inducted Karnataka minister



B Nagendra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The BJP on Wednesday lashed out at the ruling Congress for re-inducting B Nagendra, who was allegedly involved in the ₹89 crore Valmiki Tribes Development Corporation scam, into the State Cabinet and warned of protest if he continues in the post.

Ballari rural Congress MLA Nagendra was among the 19 ministers who took the oath on Monday, two months after DK Shivakumar assumed charge as the chief minister. Chalavadi Narayanaswamy, Leader of Opposition in the Legislative Council, announced that the BJP would launch a statewide agitation if Nagendra was not dropped from the Cabinet and warned that the party would not allow the Assembly session beginning August 13 to function without his resignation.

He also accused the Congress of "auctioning" ministerial berths in the recently expanded State Cabinet. Addressing a press conference, the BJP leader said videos and conversations circulating in the public domain supported his allegation that Cabinet positions had been secured through monetary influence.

Narayanaswamy said, "The Congress had put ministeri-

al berths up for auction. Whoever could pay according to their capacity got the posts."

The BJP leader further claimed that conversations between senior Congress leaders indicated that "honest" legislators who did not have money were overlooked for ministerial posts. Citing a recorded conversation, he claimed that party leaders had suggested that those who remained honest without accumulating money could not expect ministerial positions.

Referring to Nagendra, Narayanaswamy alleged that despite facing corruption charges and being out on bail, he had been rewarded with a ministerial post. This proves the Congress supports corruption, he alleged. Warning of intensified protests, Narayanaswamy said, "Until Nagendra resigns, we will not stop our agitation. The Assembly session begins on August 13. Without his resignation, we will not allow the House to function."

He urged Shivakumar to obtain Nagendra's resignation immediately.

Barely a year after Congress came to power, the Karnataka Maharishi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation Limited (KMVSTDCL) scam rocked the State.

Karnataka minister Khandre orders SOPs for VB-G RAM G scheme implementation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Minister Eshwar Khandre on Wednesday directed officials to issue SOPs and administrative and technical guidelines to all gram panchayats to facilitate the effective rollout of the VB-G RAM G scheme and boost rural employment amid the rainfall deficit.

In a written communication to the department's secretary, Karnataka Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Minister Eshwar Khandre stated that the State Government had introduced the VB-G RAM G scheme to replace MGNREGA, despite financial constraints, with the intention of safeguarding the interests of the rural poor and other disadvantaged sections, according to a release from his office.

He instructed officials to circulate standard operating procedures, technical specifications and administrative guidelines to all gram panchayats to facilitate large-scale employment generation and the creation



Eshwar Khandre

of durable, high-quality rural assets.

The minister noted that some Panchayat Development Officers had reported difficulties in implementing the scheme due to the absence of clear operational guidelines.

He instructed the department to issue detailed implementation guidelines covering SOPs, technical and administrative procedures, model estimates, approved works, expenditure limits, the 60:40 wage-to-material ratio, the operation of the Yuktadhara web-based

geospatial planning portal, the accountability framework, and action plan formats.

Khandre said that although no Chief Executive Officer of a Zilla Panchayat had flagged implementation issues during a meeting chaired by the Chief Secretary, confusion persisted at the field level and needed to be addressed without delay.

Stressing the need to expand employment opportunities in view of the rainfall deficit, the minister said the scheme's objective

would be defeated if adequate employment was not provided to the rural poor, marginalised and deprived communities, persons with disabilities, women and Dalits.

He directed officials to include details of the 318 approved works under the VB-G RAM G scheme, model designs, the schedule of rates, technical notes and standard specifications in the implementation guidelines, and ensure their strict enforcement across the State.

Khandre instructed officials to undertake intensive door-to-door awareness campaigns through interpersonal communication to inform rural households about the individual and community works available under the scheme.

The minister said the Government aims to provide employment to at least five lakh people every day, generate a minimum of 1.5 crore person-days of work every month, and create durable, high-quality rural assets across the State.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Wednesday directed officials to expedite land acquisition for industrial projects, saying the timely availability of land is crucial to sustain the State's industrial expansion and attract investments.

Chairing a review meeting for projects under the Maharashtra Industrial Development Corporation (MIDC), the CM asked officials to simplify procedures, reduce administrative delays and ensure faster clearances for land allotment, said an official release issued after the meeting.

He said Maharashtra has



been witnessing rapid expansion of industrial estates and stressed that land required for industries should be made available within stipulated timelines.

Fadnavis said the state's online MILAP (Maharashtra Industrial Land Application

& Allotment Portal) system has made industrial plot allotment more transparent by enabling online applications, real-time tracking, automated issuance of offer letters and allotment orders, and dashboard-based monitoring.

Between October 1, 2025 and July 31, 2026, the state allotted 1,183 industrial plots, generating revenue of ₹5,502 crore, he said.

According to the chief minister, land acquisition for about 66,343 acres is currently underway across many districts, including Gadchiroli, Chandrapur, Nagpur, Pune, Palghar, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Thane, Ratnagiri, Raigad, Nashik and Wardha.

Andhra Govt targets ₹9 lakh crore investment in Visakhapatnam region

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

The Andhra Pradesh Government is aiming to attract investments of up to ₹9 lakh crore across various sectors in the VER. As part of the Visakhapatnam Economic Region project, the State Government plans to invest between ₹3.5 lakh crore and ₹4 lakh crore, and attract up to ₹5.3 lakh crore from the private sector, a press release said on Wednesday.

The VER project is expected to attract up to ₹9.3 lakh crore through key projects across various sectors. The State Government will invest between ₹3.5 lakh crore and ₹4 lakh crore, while attracting ₹5.3 lakh crore from the private sector, the release said.

Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu reviewed the VER development plan at his camp office in Undavalli. Positioning the 'Bay City' project as its anchor, the state aims to develop the



VER region. "The goal of the VER project is to develop the entire Visakhapatnam region through micro-level planning," Naidu said.

The development plan includes an AI data centre ecosystem, port-related industries, tourism, and hydrogen, clean-tech and energy projects, the press release said.

Naidu instructed officials that VER development should extend from Mulapeta Port to Rajahmundry's Akhanda Godavari project, and called for convergence of funds, along with Viability Gap Funding, wherever required.

Government stresses science, tech to tackle wildlife conflict

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The challenge of human-wildlife conflict must be addressed through a balanced approach that combines scientific management, institutional coordination, technology-enabled monitoring, and active involvement of local communities, Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav said on Wednesday.

The minister made the comments at a meeting of the Parliamentary

Consultative Committee of the Environment Ministry. During the meeting chaired by Yadav, the measures required to strengthen prevention, mitigation, and long-term coexistence between people and wildlife were discussed.

The committee was informed about the establishment of the Centre of Excellence on Human-Wildlife Conflict (CoE-HWC) in Coimbatore, Tamil Nadu. The centre is a national institution for scientific research, technological



Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav

innovation, policy support, capacity building and community-centred approaches for effective management of human-wildlife conflict.

The committee also noted the launch of the National Human-Wildlife Conflict Portal on July 10, as a unified digital platform for recording conflict incidents, data management, knowledge sharing, and decision support.

Yadav emphasised that these measures would provide an important institutional framework for

developing data-driven strategies, facilitating knowledge exchange, and supporting States in adopting best practices.

Moreover, the meeting witnessed presentations by Assam, Karnataka, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Uttar Pradesh, highlighting their conflict scenarios, mitigation measures, community participation initiatives, use of technology, institutional mechanisms, and recommendations for strengthening national efforts.



Editor's

TAKE

Bangladesh reset: India's strategic dilemma

Two years after Sheikh Hasina's exile in India, New Delhi finds itself navigating one of the most delicate diplomatic transitions in its neighbourhood

Two years ago, on the afternoon of August 5, 2024, Sheikh Hasina boarded a military aircraft in Dhaka and landed hours later at Hindon Air Base outside Delhi, ending more than fifteen unbroken years in power and, with them, the closest strategic partnership India had built with any government in its eastern neighbourhood. In the twenty-four months since, Bangladesh has moved through more upheaval than most countries see in a decade. An interim government led by the Nobel laureate Muhammad Yunus took charge within days of Hasina's fall, promising reform and, eventually, elections.

Later, the Bangladesh Nationalist Party, led by Tarique Rahman, won that election, and Rahman was sworn in as Prime Minister. Dhaka has been demanding the extradition of Sheikh Hasina, convicted of mass murder and sentenced to death. It has repeated the request several times since her sentencing, invoking the bilateral extradition treaty the two countries signed in 2013. India's reluctance to hurry an answer on extradition is often described in Delhi as caution; it would be more accurately described as a considered legal position.

India can no longer treat this as a waiting game, because Bangladesh is not waiting either. Prime Minister Rahman's own language has been careful – he has spoken of shaping foreign policy around the interests of Bangladesh and its people rather than old alignments and has avoided the anti-India rhetoric of the interim years. However, his leaning towards China is unmistakable. His first foreign visit as Prime Minister was to Beijing, not Delhi, despite Modi's early invitation. China has since pledged support for the long-delayed Teesta river management project – a scheme India itself had offered to help fund. Reportedly, China has gained a foothold at Bangladesh's Mongla Port and is discussing a China-Myanmar-Bangladesh economic corridor that would give Beijing another route to the Bay of Bengal. Dhaka's military and civilian contacts with Islamabad, revived through the interim years, have shown no clear sign of reversing under the new government.

India has the precarious task of managing Dhaka while not conceding its demand for Hasina's extradition. Violence that followed Hasina's fall did not end with her departure or with the election. Minority rights groups recorded several attacks on Hindus and other minorities in the first six months of this year alone, and 44 deaths – evidence that the intimidation of Bangladesh's minorities has become a structural problem.

The most useful thing India can do for its own standing in Dhaka is finish what it has spent fifteen years promising. Reviving the Teesta project on workable terms, pushing the free trade talks that have moved at a crawl, and fast-tracking connectivity and energy projects would do more to blunt China's advances than any number of *démarches* about Mongla Port. The task now is difficult, though doable: hold the legal line on Hasina without turning it into theatre, and do the patient work – on water, trade, connectivity and minority rights – that wins back a neighbourhood India cannot afford to lose to Beijing.

Why the BJP must reconnect with Gen X

Every successful political party eventually confronts the challenge of a changing electorate. For the BJP, that challenge comes from Generation X – a demographic shaped by economic reforms, political upheavals and decades of institutional change



KALYANI SHANKAR

The political scene in India is changing quickly, and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is facing a key moment in its history. It needs to think about how to engage Generation X. The ruling Modi government struggled with Generation X, which launched an unexpected agitation that took the government by surprise. This group has evolved through economic and political events. The new Anti-Leak Bill aims to improve transparency in government dealings.

Generation X is described as the “forgotten generation” or the “middle child” between the larger Baby Boomer and Millennial cohorts. A distinct sense of independence, pragmatism and scepticism towards established institutions characterises this demographic. Generation X has experienced significant national and global events, including economic recessions, the emergence of the internet and critical political transformations. Many individuals within this cohort encountered challenges in the job market during the 1990s and were affected by the implications of liberalisation policies, which presented both opportunities and uncertainties.

This generation values authenticity and practicality, focusing on real benefits rather than empty promises. For Generation X, this means they will carefully examine how the Anti-Leak Bill affects real life. To win their support, it is important to clearly explain what the Bill aims to do and how it protects people.

Last week, Parliament passed the Anti-Leak Bill to stop information leaks that could threaten national security and public safety. This Bill has received mixed reviews. It raises important questions about how to balance national security with individual freedoms. Critics believe that, while protecting sensitive information is important, the Bill could be misused. They worry it might undermine freedoms such as free speech and limit the space for different viewpoints. It is also worth noting that the Anti-Leak Bill was created to prevent information leaks in examinations.

These concerns are very important to Generation X, who value accountability and transparency in government. Many Gen Xers see this legislation as a repeat of past government actions, where laws meant for security were used to silence dissent. They are understandably cautious and sceptical.



THE BJP CAN USE DIGITAL PLATFORMS FOR OUTREACH, POLICY DISCUSSIONS AND EDUCATIONAL CAMPAIGNS. BY ANALYSING DATA AND USING SOCIAL MEDIA INSIGHTS, THE PARTY CAN FOCUS ITS MESSAGES ON THE ISSUES THAT MATTER MOST TO GENERATION X

The writer is a popular columnist

To win back Generation X, the BJP needs a clear strategy. This strategy should do more than promote policies or highlight guaranteed outcomes. Several additional approaches could help achieve this goal.

First, genuine engagement with Generation X through town halls and social media can make them feel respected and included in decision-making processes, strengthening their connection with the party.

Secondly, face-to-face engagement fosters a sense of community and validation for voters. At the same time, digital platforms can facilitate wider outreach, especially appealing to the more tech-savvy members of Generation X.

Thirdly, prioritising transparency by clearly explaining the Anti-Leak Bill's objectives and safeguards can help Generation X feel reassured and trust the BJP's commitment to their interests.

Fourthly, sharing information in simple formats such as infographics and public bulletins can attract a generation that wants quick and clear answers. In addition, involving experts in discussions can strengthen the party's credibility and show that it is inclusive and responsive.

Fifthly, the BJP should actively promote and highlight its successes in areas that resonate with Generation X's values. Economic stability, job creation, skill development initiatives and success in digital governance are all subjects that can positively influence this group.

Sixthly, emphasising meaningful development projects and policies that have directly impacted the lives of Gen Xers can help reinforce the party's commitment to their well-being. Reassuring Generation X about the importance of individual rights is paramount. The BJP should explain how the Anti-

Leak Bill supports democratic values. They need to show the safeguards in place, mention that there will be independent oversight, and highlight that there are ways for people to express their concerns. This can help bridge the trust gap with this sceptical demographic.

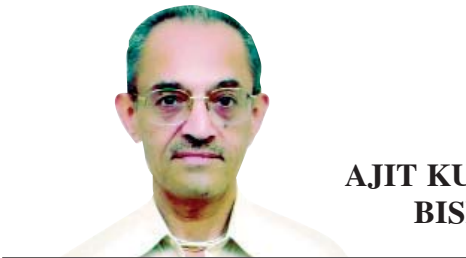
Seventhly, by engaging civil society and involving diverse voices in discussions about governance and policy, the BJP can showcase its investment in a democratic framework that values collective and individual rights.

The BJP can use digital platforms for outreach, policy discussions and educational campaigns. By analysing data and using social media insights, the party can focus its messages on the issues that matter most to Generation X. This approach will help ensure that communication connects with them on a personal level. While the Anti-Leak Bill presents challenges for the BJP in regaining generational trust, it is also an opportunity for the party to evolve its approach and demonstrate its commitment to accountability and openness. Winning back Generation X will demand sustained effort, fostering an environment where the party can position itself as a progressive party that values the voices of all demographics, including Generation X. Winning back Generation X after the Anti-Leak Bill, the party can regain trust and support from this group. The BJP should engage with them, be transparent, respect their rights and use technology effectively. Gen X plays an important role in Indian politics, so the BJP must pay attention to improving its image with them. By using clear strategies and building real connections, the BJP can strengthen its relationship with Gen X.

PIC TALK



A farmer carrying a plough passes by as dark monsoon clouds hover, in Nadia district, West Bengal. PHOTO: PTI



AJIT KUMAR BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

First of all, it must be understood that sleeping is a basic necessity of the material body. This, along with eating, is essential for the material body to exist. Lord Krishna has instructed us in the Bhagavad Gita to sleep and stay awake as required (6.17), that is, neither too much nor too little (6.16). In short, it should be *yukta* (just right).

What is right varies at different ages. A tiny infant sleeps almost round the clock, except when he or she wakes up to be fed. Children require seven to eight hours of sleep to rejuvenate their tired bodies. This continues into youth, although it is closer to seven hours. As one advances to middle age, the requirement is still around seven hours, but it begins to become difficult to manage, especially if the mind is disturbed. This problem gets worse in old age. There is less deep sleep;



one wakes up early, and even total sleep is affected. Naps during the day are required to maintain the necessary energy level.

The important question that must be answered is: Can one manage with naps if there is deficient sleep at night, which is normally the case in old age? The answer, fortunately, is yes. A good sleep after lunch restores the body to a good energy level, and the mind is refreshed. Some older people take two or three naps during the day, which keep them going.

All this is fine, but there are normally problems in sleeping well, beginning from middle age. If advancing age is a problem in itself, most people compound it by having

impossible dreams that are never going to be fulfilled. Added to this is *bhogabhava* (the mood of sense enjoyment), which is never satisfied. Material attractions are embraced, and the mind, which is key to good sleep, gets affected. What people do then is even worse. Rather than accepting the reality of age causing changes in sleep patterns, they resort to drinking alcohol, taking sleeping pills or even drugs to get to sleep. In developed countries such as the USA, 54 per cent of the adult population drinks alcohol, and around 10 per cent take sedatives to sleep. An overinflated ego does not allow one to look for the real solution, which is taking shelter in God.

How can God help? He begins to reform the person if one takes His shelter and decides to remain in it. Systematically, God guides one towards solutions to individual problems. As one experiences these changes, one starts to become hopeful. One begins to look after one's health seriously rather than lamenting one's luck. One begins to accept the reality that the Earth is a *duhkhalaya* (place of misery), as are the changes in sleep patterns. One becomes a devotee, and the mind starts to become peaceful. Night-time dreams are no longer scary and disturbing. There are other benefits as well to being under the shelter of God. He provides what one lacks, including good sleep, and protects what one has, giving hope for a smooth life from now onwards.

The writer is a spiritual teacher

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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BUILDING STRONG READING HABITS FOR A BETTER FUTURE

This refers to the news report, “Government directs schools to introduce daily 30-minute reading session, library activities” (August 5). The Delhi government's decision to strengthen reading habits in schools is a timely and welcome initiative.

At a time when many students are increasingly drawn to mobile phones, social media and other electronic devices, regular reading can restore attention, curiosity and independent thinking. Books encourage patience, imagination and deeper understanding in ways that short digital content rarely can. However, the success of this initiative will depend on consistent implementation rather than another well-intentioned circular.

Schools must ensure that libraries are well stocked with age-appropriate and diverse books, including literature in

regional languages. Teachers should be encouraged to discuss books with students instead of treating reading as a silent routine or merely another academic task. Reading clubs, storytelling sessions, author interactions and peer recommendations can make reading enjoyable rather than compulsory.

Parents, too, have an important role in creating a reading culture at home by setting aside time to read with their children and limiting unnecessary screen exposure. School libraries should remain active learning spaces throughout the year, with librarians guiding students according to their interests and reading levels. If children discover the joy of reading early, they are more likely to become informed, thoughtful and responsible citizens.

K SAKUNTHALA | COIMBATORE

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

The foundation of India's future

India's ability to sustain high economic growth depends on the strength of its talent base. While the country has one of the world's largest workforces, the priority now is developing deep-tech, advanced manufacturing and digital skills. These capabilities will strengthen competitiveness not only in IT services but also in manufacturing, infrastructure, healthcare, public administration and other innovation-driven sectors.

India must also expand its design and manufacturing capabilities, focusing not just on scale but on sophistication. The shift from assembly-led production to value-chain leadership requires Industry 4.0 technologies, automation, design expertise and export readiness. With better access to credit, AI tools, quality systems and logistics, MSMEs can integrate into global supply chains and boost exports. Equally important is strengthening both physical and digital infrastructure. Investments in logistics, transport networks and industrial capacity must complement India's digital public infrastructure, including identity systems, payment platforms and data exchange networks. The next phase lies in converting these digital assets into industry-led products and services that drive innovation, productivity and long-term economic growth, positioning India as a global technology and manufacturing hub.

CK SURESH | BANGALORE

Youth power driving India's self-reliance

India is undergoing a defining phase of transformation, with its youth emerging as the driving force behind the nation's progress. Across education, skill development, entrepreneurship, innovation, sports and public service, young Indians are shaping a future marked by confidence, creativity and excellence. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has identified the poor, youth, farmers and women as the four pillars of a developed India. Among them, the youth occupy a pivotal position as the architects of Viksit Bharat 2047.

Recognised as the *Amrit Peedhi*, they are actively building the nation through talent, determination and enterprise. Over the past 12 years, the Government of India has invested in expanding opportunities in education, startups, innovation, public service, sports and the creative economy to unlock the potential of young Indians.

The 2014-2026 period has witnessed a shift towards digitised governance, structural economic formalisation and large-scale infrastructure development. Flagship initiatives such as Digital India and Make in India have helped move the country from fragmented systems to integrated national frameworks, promoting financial inclusion, strengthening manufacturing capabilities and advancing the goal of self-reliance.

C K SUBRAMANIAM | MUMBAI

An irreplaceable loss to Indian cinema

The demise of veteran actor Pradeep Rawat at the age of 74 has brought grief to the film fraternity and millions of cinema enthusiasts. Throughout his distinguished career, he earned widespread appreciation for portraying strong, impactful characters that left a lasting impression on audiences.

His remarkable performances across Hindi and regional cinema reflected his immense talent and unwavering dedication to the craft of acting.

Pradeep Rawat's journey serves as a reminder that cinema flourishes because of artists who bring sincerity and conviction to every role, regardless of its prominence. His commanding performances, remarkable versatility and professional commitment enriched countless films and set a high standard for aspiring actors. His passing also highlights the importance of recognising the invaluable contribution of character actors, who often remain the backbone of meaningful storytelling.

As the curtain falls on the life of a distinguished performer, Pradeep Rawat leaves behind a legacy that will continue to inspire the world of cinema. His unforgettable performances and lasting contribution to Indian cinema will always be cherished, ensuring that his memory lives on in the hearts of audiences for years to come.

RUKMA SHARMA | JALANDHAR

Beyond punishment: Restoring the soul of India’s examination system

The passage of the Public Examinations Amendment Bill, 2026, marks an important attempt to restore public confidence. But the legislation will achieve its purpose only if it becomes part of a broader reform agenda that strengthens institutions, embraces technology, and rebuilds trust in the integrity of public examinations



“The future of a nation is not stolen only on the battlefield; sometimes it is stolen silently, in a room where a question paper is sold before the examination begins.”

Every year, millions of young Indians walk into examination halls carrying more than admit cards. They carry the dreams of parents who sacrificed comforts, teachers who nurtured hope, and a nation that believes education remains the fairest path to opportunity. For many families, a single examination is not merely a test-it is the turning point of generations.

Yet, when a question paper is leaked, something far greater than an examination is compromised. It is not merely the sanctity of a test that is broken; it is the faith of honest students, the dignity of public institutions, and the moral promise of our Republic.

The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, passed by both Houses of Parliament during the Monsoon Session 2026, is therefore more than an amendment to the law enacted in 2024. It serves as an affirmation that the dreams of India's youth are not commodities to be bought and sold. It is a national resolve that merit shall never again become the victim of organised crime.

For too long, irregularities in the examination process have been treated as isolated incidents. In truth, every paper leak is an organised assault on justice. Behind every leaked question paper lies a chain of corruption-brokers, middlemen, technology experts, dishonest officials, organised criminal syndicates, and those who profit from the desperation of students. As noted by the K Radhakrishnan-led Committee of Experts, established in 2024, vulnerabilities exist throughout the entire testing cycle that have been exploited for a long time.

History teaches us an uncomfortable truth. The crisis before us did not arise overnight, nor is it the failure of any one government or one institution. Successive governments, across decades, struggled with recurring weaknesses in examination security, investigation, and accountability. Institutions often reacted after the damage had already been done. Criminals learnt that the rewards were enormous while the risks remained limited. Such softness emboldened organised networks whose only objective was profit, regardless of the shattered futures they left behind. The world now watches India not merely as the largest democracy but as a rising knowledge economy. Every examination scandal echoes beyond our borders, raising questions about the credibility of our educational institutions. A nation aspiring to lead in science, technology, medicine and innovation cannot afford uncertainty in the very examinations that identify its future talent.

For this reason, stronger punishment is both necessary and justified. Those who organise paper leaks are not committing ordinary offences; they are committing crimes against the future of the nation.

It has been observed that, in many recent cases, leaks have come to light after citizens, including whistleblowers and teachers/professors, found that some copies of papers already in circulation matched exactly with the papers that were used in the examination. The inability of the testing agencies and concerned authorities to identify irregularities reflects key gaps in the internal detection machinery of examination authorities. A revamped, dedicated vigilance wing must be created in all public examination bodies. It should be manned by permanent staff, with adequate safeguards against conflicts of interest.

A law that punishes criminals but ignores institutional shortcomings remains incomplete. Accountability must extend beyond the accused to every authority entrusted with protecting public examinations.

The National Testing Agency and every examination-conducting body must become institutions that are transparent, answerable, and willing to learn from every mistake. After every major examination, they should publish an Examination Integrity Report explaining what worked, what failed, what vulnerabilities were identified, and how those weaknesses will be permanently corrected. The Government should also take the necessary steps to bring the National Testing Agency within the scope of statutory audits by the Comptroller and



THE PUBLIC EXAMINATIONS (PREVENTION OF UNFAIR MEANS) AMENDMENT BILL, 2026, PASSED BY BOTH HOUSES OF PARLIAMENT DURING THE MONSOON SESSION 2026, IS THEREFORE MORE THAN AN AMENDMENT TO THE LAW ENACTED IN 2024. IT SERVES AS AN AFFIRMATION THAT THE DREAMS OF INDIA'S YOUTH ARE NOT COMMODITIES TO BE BOUGHT AND SOLD. IT IS A NATIONAL RESOLVE THAT MERIT SHALL NEVER AGAIN BECOME THE VICTIM OF ORGANISED CRIME

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Auditor General (CAG).

The Ministry of Education must also complete an equally important responsibility. Numerous expert bodies-including the K Radhakrishnan Committee, the Justice AK Ranjan Committee, parliamentary committees, and ministerial panels-have invested immense intellectual effort in examining examination reforms. Their recommendations should not remain confined to government files. A comprehensive Action Taken Report detailing which recommendations have been implemented must be placed before both Houses of Parliament for perusal by elected representatives. The greatest lesson emerging from these committees is that technology should become our strongest ally.

In the twenty-first century, we trust technology with our banking, our taxation, our passports, our digital identities, and even the conduct of elections. It is therefore legitimate to ask: why should millions of high-stakes examinations continue to rely predominantly on vulnerable paper-based systems when safer technological alternatives are available?

India must gradually embrace secure computer-based testing wherever infrastructure permits. Artificial intelligence, encrypted digital transmission, blockchain-enabled audit trails, biometric authentication, cyber-security monitoring, and real-time digital surveillance should become the guardians of examination integrity. Technology cannot eliminate every risk, but it can make organised fraud extraordinarily difficult and far easier to detect. A strong forensic infrastructure is indispensable for the effective investigation and prosecution of paper leak offences, as modern examination fraud is increasingly orchestrated through digital means rather than conventional physical methods. However, technology alone cannot solve an educational problem whose roots lie much deeper. The dependence of students on expensive private coaching reflects another challenge. When success in national entrance examinations appears impossible without years of coaching, it raises serious questions about the strength of our school education system.

Low government investment in education remains a critical structural challenge in India, with combined Union and State spending hovering around 4.1% of GDP-falling well short of the long-standing 6% target recommended by various panels.

Government schools must once again become centres of academic excellence through sustained investment in enhancing their competitiveness. Science education at the higher secondary level should be modernised, laboratories strengthened, and teachers continuously trained in contemporary teaching methods.

Private coaching centres undoubtedly support many students, but their rapid expansion also demands responsible regulation. Perhaps the most overlooked voices in examination reform are those who experience the system first-hand. Students know where fear exists. Parents understand the emotional burden of uncertainty. Teachers witness the strengths and weaknesses of the process from within. Their collective wisdom should become part of public policy.

Ultimately, no reform can succeed without leadership. Leadership is not measured only by authority during moments of success; it is measured by responsibility during moments of failure. Accountability should never be viewed as blame. It is the foundation upon which public trust is rebuilt.

India's youth deserve more than promises. They deserve an examination system where preparation matters more than privilege, honesty triumphs over manipulation, and merit is never defeated by money or influence.

Universities, sustainability and the idea of self-reliance



The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), adopted by the United Nations in 2015, set out seventeen global goals to improve quality of life, protect the environment and promote sustainable development by 2030. Although they were framed as a global development agenda, their relevance extends well beyond governments and international organisations. Universities have an equally important role because they educate future professionals, generate new knowledge and help shape the values that influence society. For institutions of higher learning, the SDGs provide a practical framework for thinking about teaching, research, campus development and community engagement.

Having served as Vice-Chancellor of Jamia Hamdard for five years, I came to appreciate that sustainability cannot be understood through isolated projects or policy statements alone. It is reflected in the choices a university makes every day. Decisions relating to energy use, water conservation, waste management, research priorities and student engagement together determine whether sustainability becomes part of an institution's culture or remains an administrative objective. Sustainability is most effective when it becomes part of the way a university functions rather than a collection of independent activities. Those experiences also shaped my understanding of self-reliance. Discussions on Atmanirbhar Bharat often focus on manufacturing, technology and economic growth, while sustainability is viewed largely through the lens of environmental protection. Universities bring these two ideas together in a natural way. Against this background, several Sustainable Development Goals assume particular importance for higher education.

SDG 4: Quality Education lies at the heart of every university. It calls for inclusive and equitable education while promoting life-long learning. For universities, this means far more than increasing enrolment. Students must also graduate with the knowledge, skills and values needed to respond to social, economic and environmental challenges. Sustainability should therefore not remain confined to a single elective course or an annual awareness programme. It should gradually become part of teaching across disciplines.

During my tenure, I found that this was often the most demanding aspect of institutional leadership. Building infrastructure is comparatively straightforward.

SDG 6: Clean Water and Sanitation carries particular significance for Indian universities, many of which operate in regions facing increasing pressure on water resources. Responsible water management is therefore no longer simply an environmental concern; it is an institutional responsibility. Rainwater harvesting, wastewater treatment, ground-water recharge and efficient water use should form part of long-term campus planning rather than isolated environmental initiatives. At Jamia Hamdard, sustained investment in rainwater harvesting and water conservation demonstrated how environmental responsibility could be translated into institutional practice. Recognition received for these efforts was encouraging, but the larger achievement lay in making responsible water management part of the University's everyday functioning.

SDG 7: Affordable and Clean Energy reminds universities that sustainability must also be reflected in the way campuses are planned and managed. A modern university consumes significant amounts of electricity through laboratories, classrooms, libraries, hospitals, hostels and administrative buildings. Energy decisions therefore affect both the environment and institutional finances. During my tenure at Jamia Hamdard, we continued to expand the use of solar energy as part of a broader effort to reduce dependence on conventional power sources. The objective was not simply to lower energy costs but to demonstrate that renewable energy could become a normal part of university life.

SDG 9: Industry, Innovation and Infrastructure highlights another responsibility that universities carry. Research has always been central to higher education, but its significance extends well beyond publication and academic recognition. Universities contribute to national development when they encourage innovation, strengthen research infrastructure and work with industry to solve practical problems.

SDG 11: Sustainable Cities and Communities extends the University's responsibility beyond its own campus. Universities are closely connected with the cities and neighbourhoods in which they are located through healthcare services, legal aid, extension activities, environmental awareness programmes and community engagement. Their contribution should therefore be assessed not only through academic performance but also through the positive influence they have on the communities they serve.

SDG 12: Responsible Consumption and Production draws attention to the everyday decisions that shape the culture of a campus. Waste segregation, recycling, responsible procurement, composting, e-waste management and the efficient use of resources may appear to be administrative matters, yet together they reflect the values an institution seeks to promote. Jamia Hamdard continued to strengthen these practices through waste management initiatives, recycling programmes and environmentally responsible campus management.

SDG 13: Climate Action provides the broader context within which many of these initiatives come together. Climate change is no longer an issue confined to environmental science. It affects public health, agriculture, infrastructure, urban development and economic planning. Universities therefore have a responsibility to respond through teaching, research and institutional practice. During my tenure, environmental awareness programmes, workshops and academic activities organised through the Centre for Environment and Sustainable Development encouraged students and faculty to engage with these questions in a meaningful way. No university can achieve these objectives in isolation, which makes SDG 17: Partnerships for the Goals particularly important. Collaboration with government agencies, research institutions, industry and civil society creates opportunities that no single university can achieve on its own. Such partnerships strengthen research, expand opportunities for students and allow institutions to share knowledge and good practices.



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India’s labour codes: A defining reform for the 2047 growth story



Achieving the vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047 will depend as much on modernising India's labour market as on strengthening its infrastructure, technological capabilities, and capital base. A young demographic alone does not guarantee growth; it must be supported by institutions that enable productivity, mobility, and formalisation at scale. In this context, the Labour Codes assume strategic importance. They are not merely a consolidation of twenty-nine labour laws, but a reorientation of how India balances flexibility, protection, and competitiveness in its labour market.

The Code on Wages seeks to establish a more harmonised and equitable wage framework. The statutory floor wage, to be determined by the Central Government, is intended to create a national wage baseline to reduce inter-state and inter-sectoral disparities and strengthen income

protection. This is complemented by a uniform definition of wages to minimise interpretational ambiguities, ensure consistency in compliance, and limit regulatory arbitrage, thereby enhancing clarity and predictability in wage-setting.

A second pillar of the reforms focuses on enhancing labour market flexibility while retaining core worker protections. The provision for fixed-term employment enables enterprises to adjust workforce requirements in line with demand conditions while ensuring parity in wages and statutory benefits with permanent workers. This is complemented by enabling provisions on working hours, shift arrangements, and overtime, which provide operational flexibility, particularly for sectors integrated with global production and service delivery cycles.

The Codes also seek to rationalise and strengthen India's industrial relations framework. The Code provides for the recognition of a negotiating union or, where no single union meets the prescribed threshold, a negotiating council, thereby creating a structured mechanism for collective bargaining and worker-employer engagement. This is complemented by the provision for a National Industrial Tribunal within the industrial dispute resolution architecture, alongside broader efforts to make dispute resolution more structured and efficient. The higher threshold for prior permission in cases of lay-off, retrenchment, and closure shifts the regulatory balance for larger establishments.

Reducing the compliance burden is a key objective of the Codes. The framework provides for single registration and the possibility of an all-



India licence for certain categories of establishments, alongside simplified filing requirements, with the aim of addressing barriers to scale for enterprises with multi-state operations. This, together with digitised registration, compliance, and inspection systems, is expected to lower transaction costs, streamline regulatory processes, and improve the ease of doing business, particularly for MSMEs transitioning towards formalisation.

Worker welfare and inclusion also constitute a core component of the framework. The extension of social security coverage to gig and platform workers, along with their recognition as a distinct category, reflects the evolving nature of employment and the increasing role of platform-based work. In parallel, provisions relating to women's night-shift work, subject to consent and safety safeguards, as well as crèche facilities under the welfare framework, may support higher female labour

force participation and expand opportunities across sectors. The Codes also seek to standardise the framework governing occupational safety, health, and working conditions. They provide for a single, tripartite National Occupational Safety and Health Advisory Board, with representation from governments, employers, and workers, to advise on standards and regulatory frameworks.

Taken together, these provisions indicate a shift towards a labour market framework aligned with the requirements of a modern and evolving, globally integrated economy. In manufacturing sectors such as electronics, textiles, and auto components, enhanced hiring flexibility, clearer industrial relations mechanisms, and streamlined compliance systems are expected to support productivity and facilitate integration into global value chains. For MSMEs, simplified regulatory processes and reduced compliance burdens may enable gradual formalisation and improved access to finance and markets. In services and emerging sectors, including the platform economy, the recognition of new categories of workers and the extension of social security are expected to enhance both worker welfare and labour market efficiency. The enabling framework for flexible workforce arrangements, supported by clearer regulatory norms, is particularly relevant for sectors characterised by dynamic demand conditions and evolving business models.

However, the effectiveness of these reforms will depend on their implementation within India's federal framework. As labour is a Concurrent Subject, variations in state-level notification and

enforcement may result in uneven outcomes across jurisdictions. The continued applicability of legacy state legislation, such as the Mathadi Act (1969) in Maharashtra and the Kerala Headload Workers Act (1978), could create regulatory overlaps and constrain the objective of a harmonised national framework. Administrative capacity will also be a critical determinant of outcomes.

The effectiveness of digitised compliance frameworks, inspection systems, and dispute resolution mechanisms will depend on institutional readiness at the state level. Addressing these challenges will require sustained Centre-State coordination, supported by continuous, structured engagement with industry, worker representatives, and other relevant stakeholders. Targeted investments in digital infrastructure, institutional capacity, and awareness generation will be essential to translate the intent of the reforms into effective on-the-ground outcomes. The Labour Codes represent a structural reform in India's labour market architecture, with the potential to recalibrate the balance between regulation, competitiveness, and inclusion. Their effectiveness will depend on the quality of implementation and institutionalisation across jurisdictions. As India advances towards the vision of Viksit Bharat, the Codes can serve as a key enabler of a more productive, formalised, and globally competitive workforce, supporting sustained and resilient growth.

The writers are Apurva Chandra, former Secretary to the Government of India, and Kaushal Mahan, Managing Principal, Chase Advisors

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Order Order

Can't interfere in democratic process of Bar, says SC



The Supreme Court on Wednesday refused to restrain the Supreme Court Bar Association from passing any unilateral resolution, saying it can't interfere in the democratic process of the Bar. Refusing to entertain the plea, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana said it pertains to the internal affairs of the Association.

It asked the petitioner to approach the election committee of SCBA for its grievances.

The top court was hearing a plea filed by Ashish Gopal Garg objecting to resolution passed by the Supreme Court Bar Association (SCBA) expressing solidarity with activist Sonam Wangchuk.

The plea sought directions to restrain the SCBA from passing any resolutions till elections.

The SCBA on July 16 appealed to Wangchuk to end his fast which was undertaken to draw attention to issues surrounding the NEET examinations and the broader state of the education system, saying the country needed him to remain "alive, active and engaged" rather than risk his health and life for a system in distress.

SCBA president Vikas Singh had also visited Jantar Mantar to meet Wangchuk and handed over a letter, urging him to end his fast.

In a resolution adopted by its Executive Committee, the SCBA had expressed concern over Wangchuk's fast. (PTI)

Delhi court rejects Al Falah University chairman's plea



A Delhi court has rejected two applications moved by Al Falah University chairman Jawad Ahmad Siddiqui for filing certain documents, ruling that at the stage of cognisance, it is only required to take into consideration the material placed by the complainant and not the accused.

Siddiqui claimed the documents would expose contradictions in the Enforcement Directorate's (ED) case. His other application sought a direction to the agency to provide a list of documents it was not relying upon in the prosecution complaint.

In an order dated August 4, Additional Sessions Judge Sheetal Chaudhary Pradhan said, "It is a settled law that at the stage of cognizance the court is only required to take into consideration the material placed by the complainant (in this case the prosecution complaint), for limited purpose of finding out whether a prima facie case for issue of process is made out and is limited to the aforesaid extend."

The court said at the pre-cognisance stage, it is required to examine only the material placed by the complainant to determine whether a prima facie case is made out for proceeding against the accused.

"At the stage of cognisance, the court is only required to take into consideration the material placed by the complainant," the judge observed while rejecting the plea. The defence had argued that the mandatory hearing before cognisance under the BNSS should allow an accused to place independent material before the court. It also sought supply of the list of unrelayed documents and requested that the legal issue be referred to the high court. (PTI)

Proposal for modernisation of police forces under consideration: Centre

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Wednesday told the Supreme Court that a proposal has been sent to the department of expenditure of the Ministry of Finance for in-principle approval of an umbrella scheme for modernisation of police forces across the country.

Additional Solicitor General Rajkumar Bhaskar Thakare, appearing for the Centre, told a bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta that the proposal was sent on July 8 and it is under consideration.

The apex court was hearing a batch of petitions, including a suo motu matter concerning lack of functional CCTVs in police stations.

"On July 8, a proposal has



been sent to the department of expenditure, Ministry of Finance, for in-principle approval of the umbrella scheme for modernisation of police forces. It is under consideration," the law officer said.

He said the existing funding scheme for installation of CCTVs in police stations has been extended till March 31, 2027.



SC on protests: Law enforcement agencies must show restraint

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday underscored the need for law enforcement agencies to exercise restraint during protests and said youngsters must be pacified, even if some "misguided elements" indulge in stone-pelting, as it agreed to hear a plea seeking action against organisers of the July 20 'Sansad Chalo' march for allegedly inciting violence.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana tagged the plea, filed by a retired Air Force officer, with a similar petition. Advocate Rizwan Ahmed, appearing for petitioner Maneesh Kumar Solanki, said, "Fifteen days have passed... What about the accountability of the organisers? They are going from channel to channel giving provocative statements and refusing to douse the fire".

Referring to a recent law and order incident in Rajasthan, the lawyer argued that Governments should not "bend backwards" to accommodate protesters.

"One young man has died. If the Government bends backwards in a matter con-



cerning the national capital, will it not set a precedent in Rajasthan? There also the Government will bend backwards to accommodate students. Tomorrow, if degree college students in Lucknow have some demand and start pelting stones at buses, will the Government in Uttar Pradesh also bend backwards?" he submitted.

Responding to his submission, the CJI said even if some "misguided elements" indulge in stone-pelting, youngsters are required to be pacified and counselled.

"They need advice and counselling. Any aggressive approach from the side of the mighty State may socially aggravate the situation and precipitate further violence. That needs to be

avoided," the CJI said. The lawyer contended that those involved in stone-pelting should not be allowed to go scot-free without any consideration merely because the Government was on the "wrong foot".

"This is a very dangerous precedent. Three years back, the farmers were at the Singhu border. Tomorrow, Generation Alpha, Beta, Delta will come," he said.

The lawyer further argued that Parliament was the "temple of democracy" and said if 500 people had entered the complex, "who knows whether they were carrying a country-made gun?"

"What if they had opened fire? They were not marching on a national highway. They were not marching on a

railway line. They were marching towards the temple of democracy. Everyone must be held accountable," he said.

The CJI observed that the focus should be on ensuring peaceful protests while exercising restraint if an incident occurs.

"What is important is to promote a peaceful march. If some incident takes place, the police also need to exercise a great deal of restraint to ensure that the situation does not go out of hand. Wherever such incidents take place, we need to deal with them very carefully," he said.

"We need to tread carefully, so that these youngsters do not indulge in violence. The better course is to counsel them and pacify them. The most powerful tool is listening. Listen to them and understand why they are shouting.

"But let us leave it to the wisdom of the law-enforcement agencies. They know better than you, and they know better than us, how to deal with this kind of situation," the CJI said.

The plea also sought directions to identify those who allegedly used derogatory language against police and security personnel and require them to perform community service.

Abhishek Banerjee's plea to travel abroad rejected

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Wednesday dismissed Trinamool Congress leader Abhishek Banerjee's plea to travel abroad for eye treatment. The court had earlier advised Banerjee to appear before a medical board at the state-run SSKM hospital on August 6 for its opinion on the matter. However, as the TMC leader submitted that he was not ready to do so, the court dismissed his plea to go abroad.

The court opined that such appearance before doctors at SSKM was necessary to assess Banerjee's medical condition and furnish an opinion before the bench whether it was necessary for him to go abroad or if the treatment can be administered in India.

At this stage, what is important is the treatment of the petitioner; where it will be administered is immaterial, the bench comprising Justice Saugata Bhattacharya observed. While granting interim protection in a criminal case earlier, the court had said that Banerjee cannot leave India without permission.

Challenging the order, Banerjee had moved the Supreme Court, which asked



the High Court on August 3 to decide Banerjee's plea for permission expeditiously.

Opposing Banerjee's plea, state Additional Advocate General Rajdeep Majumdar argued that several criminal prosecutions are pending against Banerjee and there is no emergent medical situation that requires the TMC leader to travel abroad for treatment.

Majumdar added that in the wake of the ongoing investigations in connection with several FIRs against Banerjee, his presence may be required in the country.

Appearing on behalf of Banerjee, senior advocate Rebecca John submitted that it was the right of the applicant to choose his doctor and medical institute for treatment, especially when it involves continuity of medical care.

NGT asks NMCG to trace origin of Budhi Ganga river in UP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Green Tribunal has directed the National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG) to submit a report identifying the origin of the Budhi Ganga river and its entire course until it merges with the Ganga river or any of its tributaries.

The green body, while hearing a matter related to encroachment of the Budhi Ganga in Uttar Pradesh, had earlier directed the authorities to demarcate the river's floodplain. In an order dated August 3, made available on

Wednesday, a bench comprising NGT Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert member Afroz Ahmad noted that the state's Irrigation and Water Resources Department had filed a report, saying physical demarcation of the Budhi Ganga floodplain and installation of boundary pillars were being carried out based on a report by the National Institute of Hydrology (NIH), Roorkee, in accordance with the Ganga Rejuvenation Order, 2016.

"Complete boundary pillar installation across all four reaches (of the river's flood-



plain zone) is on track and proposed to be fully concluded by August 30, 2026," the report said.

It said 277 pillars in Muzaffarnagar district had

been installed, while more than 50 per cent of the work in Meerut and Hapur districts was finished.

The tribunal directed the state authorities to file a

further progress report at least one week before the next hearing, confirming completion of the flood plain demarcation.

It noted the submissions of the petitioner that state authorities had provided an incorrect origin point of the Budhi Ganga river, and that he had an "authentic" 200-year-old map showing the river's origin.

The petitioner, during earlier proceedings, had pointed out that the river originates from Devel village in Muzaffarnagar and flows to Garhmukteshwar in Hapur district.

The tribunal allowed him to submit the map and other relevant material to the NMCG within a week.

"The Director General, NMCG, will duly examine the same and also take into account the other material available with him and submit a report by way of an affidavit disclosing the origin point of river Budhi Ganga and its entire track till it merges with river Ganga or any of its tributaries."

"Let this affidavit be filed at least one week before the next date of hearing (on October 16)," the tribunal said.

States cannot cite financial burden to oppose raising retirement age: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Observing that states cannot cite financial burden to oppose raising the retirement age of judicial officers, the Supreme Court on Wednesday asked state Governments to revisit the issue of enhancing the age of superannuation of judges and decide within two weeks.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana said concerns of financial burden are "misconceived".

"We impress upon all the state Governments to revisit the issue of enhancement of the age of retirement of judicial officers, irrespective of the age of superannuation prescribed for other Government employees," the bench said. The top court



said retaining experienced judicial officers may impose a lesser financial liability than retiring them and filling the resulting vacancies.

"We have no reason to doubt that the continuation of experienced and seasoned judicial officers would entail a lesser financial liability than what the State would incur upon their retirement.

"The reasons assigned by the State Governments for

declining to enhance the age of retirement are, therefore, untenable. However, we are of the considered opinion that the larger issue should be resolved through consensual measures," the bench said. In its order, the top court said the issue shall be revisited on an urgent basis and an independent and pragmatic decision shall be taken within two weeks.

"In the event a state Government decides to enhance the age of retirement, the benefit of such decision shall also be extended to judicial officers who retire during the intervening period," the bench said.

The top court had earlier asked the states and union territories to consider raising the age of superannuation of judicial officers from 60 to 61 years.

SC permits news agencies to use audio-video clips for reporting

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has clarified that its recent interim order restricting the sharing and uploading of audio and video clips of court hearings does not prevent news organisations from reporting on judicial proceedings.

The clarification came after the top court noted that "some confusion persists" over its July 24 interim order, which barred posting and uploading of audio-video recordings of judicial proceedings on social media and other digital platforms without prior permission of the court administration.

A bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant said the restriction is confined to the use of audio and video recordings of judicial proceedings in news reports and



should not be interpreted as a blanket ban on reportage by media organisations.

"It appears, however, that some confusion persists in respect of paragraph 11 of the earlier order, which this court deems necessary to clarify. The said paragraph makes it clear that the order is not to be construed as imposing a blanket prohibition on the reporting of court proceedings by recognised news outlets," the court said.

Such outlets may, there-

fore, continue to report on the proceedings and inform the general public of legal developments and judicial pronouncements, save that audio or video clips of the court proceedings shall not be utilised in the course of such reportage, it said.

"In sum, while news outlets may continue to report on the court proceedings, they shall nonetheless remain bound by the restrictions set out in paragraph 10," the bench said in its order passed on July 31.

Have undertaken efforts to eliminate NEET paper leaks: Centre tells Supreme Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre has told the Supreme Court that it has undertaken a comprehensive overhaul of the conduct of the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) to eliminate paper leaks and systemic failures.

In a compliance affidavit filed before a bench headed by Justice P S Narasimha, the Ministry of Education said the reforms are aimed at creating a robust and institutionalised system that preserves institutional memory, strengthens examination security and prevents future incidents of paper leaks or other malpractices.

The affidavit was filed in response to the apex court's May 29 direction asking the Union

Government to explain how future NEET examinations would be conducted and how regulatory authorities would build and retain institutional memory to improve examination processes over successive years.

The Government said that while the Ministry of Education oversees the National Testing Agency, NEET is conducted by the NTA on behalf of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, the test-indenting agency. It also said that the affidavit does not comment on the merits of the ongoing CBI investigation into the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak.

The Centre said Parliament has further strengthened the legal framework against examination fraud through the Public



Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Act, 2026, building on the 2024 law that criminalised question paper leaks, impersonation, tampering with computer systems and other examination-related offences.

According to the affidavit, the amendments reflect the Government's resolve to impose even stricter penalties against those compro-

mising the integrity of public examinations.

The Government also informed the court that it has constituted a High-Powered Task Force (HPTF) on Examination Reforms to recommend structural improvements in the conduct of public examinations and to modernise examination systems.

The Government said the reforms are intended to create a stronger institutional framework capable of learning from previous examination cycles through systematic use of experience, data and information, thereby reducing vulnerabilities and improving oversight.

It said the HPTF set up on July 27 is headed by Infosys co-founder and Aadhaar architect Nandan Nilekani.

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RBI holds interest rates, awaits inflation outlook

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

For the fourth consecutive time, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday kept the repo rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent and also raised its FY27 GDP growth forecast to 6.7 percent from 6.6 percent and lowered its CPI inflation projection to 5 percent from 5.1 percent. These decisions came amid build up in inflationary pressures and possibility of growth moderating due to ripple effects of the West Asia war, rising crude oil prices, a depreciating Rupee and the El Nino effect casting a shadow on the South-West monsoon. As far as inflation is concerned, it is expected to rise in the near term and peak in the third quarter of 2026-27, largely due to food and fuel prices.

Announcing the third bi-monthly monetary policy for the current fiscal, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) has unanimously decided to retain short-term lending rate or repo rate at 5.25 per cent with a neutral stance. However, it has also left millions of fixed deposit (FD) investors won-



dering whether banks could now raise deposit rates. Consequently, the standing deposit facility (SDF) rate remains at 5.00 per cent and the marginal standing facility (MSF) rate and the Bank Rate remain at 5.50 per cent.

Explaining the decision to leave the repo rate unchanged, Malhotra said the growth outlook remains hazy due to uncertainties related to the Southwest monsoon, El Niño, geopolitics and global trade policy. The prime focus of the central bank is to align the headline inflation with its target of 4 per cent over the medium term, Malhotra said at the post-policy

press conference.

The interest rate pause comes even as the Consumer Price Index (CPI) based headline retail inflation has crossed the RBI's medium-term target of 4 per cent at 4.38 per cent in June. However, RBI marginally raised the growth forecast to 6.7 per cent while lowering inflation projection to 5 per cent for the current fiscal.

Malhotra noted that headline inflation is expected to rise further and peak in the third quarter, primarily due to food and fuel and then moderate. While CPI inflation increased to 4.4 per cent in June 2026 after remaining below the

target for 16 consecutive months, it turned out to be lower by 30 basis points (bps) than what was earlier projected for Q1:2026-27. The increase in June was primarily due to higher food and fuel inflation.

The increase in food inflation was broad-based with most constituents witnessing price pressures during May-June. Fuel inflation also rose, driven by revision in retail prices, following the sharp spike in international energy prices. It also led to higher inflation in select categories such as restaurant charges. Despite the pressure from higher input costs, core (CPI excluding food and fuel) inflation remained unchanged at 3.9 per cent during May-June. Excluding precious metals, core inflation remained even lower at 2.3-2.5 per cent during this period.

Speaking to reporters at the customary briefing after the monetary policy review, Malhotra said the polymer currency notes have lasted for over 30 years in some jurisdictions and will come in handy, especially for the lower denomination notes which have high velocity. "We are targeting that they are in circulation, if everything goes as per plan, in the

beginning of the next financial year," Malhotra said.

Malhotra said the next move of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on the crucial aspect of interest rates and also the stance of the policy will be data-dependent, and underlined that the prime focus of the central bank is to align the headline inflation with its target of 4 per cent over the medium term.

Commenting on the Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) scheme, Malhotra said the flows have been "robust", and the RBI expects healthy movement of funds going forward till the closure of the limited-period scheme.

When asked if the central bank is looking to close the scheme prematurely, given that there is a cost which the RBI is committed to bear for the fund inflows, Malhotra said there is no such proposal at this point of time. After being pointed out that the rupee has not appreciated as intended despite the high flows from foreign shores, Malhotra said a further strengthening in the rupee is possible if geopolitical tensions de-escalate. It will be the RBI's endeavour that the trajectory for the rupee remains orderly, he added.

Sensex gains 152 pts in volatile session on RBI rate move

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

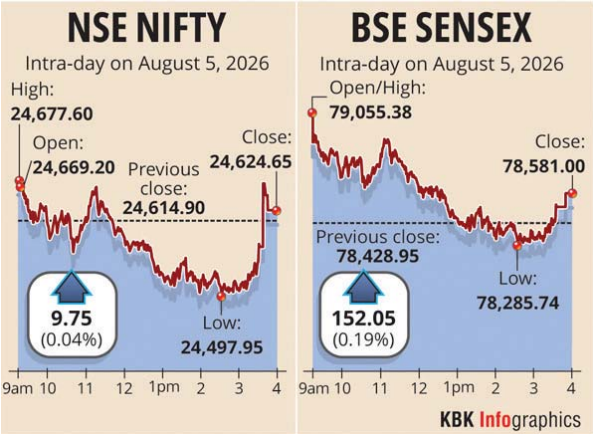
Benchmark BSE Sensex closed higher by 152 points in a volatile session on Wednesday after the Reserve Bank of India kept its key policy rates unchanged for the fourth consecutive time.

The 30-share BSE Sensex rose by 152.05 points, or 0.19 per cent, to end at 78,581 with 17 of its constituents closing with gains, 12 with losses and one unchanged. The index opened higher and hit a day's high of 79,055.38 in the first half of the session. However, the index slipped into the red in

the late afternoon session, hitting a low of 78,285.74 by losing 769.64 points. Gains bluechip banking, auto and capital goods shares in the pre-close session helped the barometer recover from losses.

The 50-share NSE Nifty edged up 9.75 points, or 0.04 per cent, to end at 24,624.65. It hit a high of 24,677.60 and a low of 24,497.95 during intraday trade.

The indices have been facing wide divergence since Monday after stock exchanges introduced a new auction mechanism for shares having futures and



options (F&O) contracts. The Closing Auction

Session (CAS) in the equity cash segment became oper-

ational on Monday, introducing a new auction-based mechanism for determining the closing prices of eligible stocks in a move aimed at making the price discovery process more transparent and robust.

Meanwhile, the Reserve Bank of India kept its benchmark policy rate unchanged for a fourth consecutive meeting on Wednesday, opting to wait for greater clarity on whether higher energy costs triggered by the Iran war feed into broader inflationary pressures.

The six-member Monetary Policy Committee, headed by

Governor Sanjay Malhotra, unanimously voted to keep the policy repo rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent and retained its "neutral" policy stance.

Marginally raising its economic growth forecast for the current financial year to 6.7 per cent from 6.6 per cent projected in June, the central bank said domestic growth remained resilient, supported by robust domestic demand, manufacturing and services activity and strong exports, despite heightened global uncertainty stemming from the West Asia conflict and trade tensions.

RBI to launch polymer currency in FY28: Guv



Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Wednesday said the Reserve Bank of India is targeting to launch long-lasting polymer currency notes at the beginning of the next financial year. Speaking to reporters at the customary briefing after the monetary policy review, Malhotra said the polymer currency notes have lasted for over 30 years in some jurisdictions and will come in handy, especially for the lower denomination notes which have high velocity. "We are targeting that they are in circulation, if everything goes as per plan, in the beginning of the next financial year," Malhotra said. Malhotra said the next move of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on the crucial aspect of interest rates and also the stance of the policy will be data-dependent, and underlined that the prime focus of the central bank is to align the headline inflation with its target of 4 per cent over the medium term. (PTI)

Google emerges as India's most attractive employer brand: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Google has emerged as India's most attractive employer brand, as revealed by the Randstad Employer Brand Research (REBR) 2026, followed by Tata Group and Amazon, according to findings of the Randstad Employer Brand Research (REBR) 2026 released on Wednesday.

The REBR 2026, which draws on insights from over 1.75 lakh respondents across 34 markets and close to 3,500 respondents in India, noted that 46 per cent of Indian talent plan to change jobs in

the next six months, while 32 per cent changed their employer in the last six months.

The other companies that feature in the top 10 most attractive employer brands in India in REBR 2026 include—Samsung India at the 4th position, Infosys (5th), Reliance Industries (6th), ITC Group (7th), Hindustan Unilever (8th), Mahindra & Mahindra (9th) and Dell Technologies Ltd (10th).

As per the survey, work-life balance, equal opportunities, career progression, salary and benefits, and a very good reputation form the core Employee Value



Proposition (EVP) drivers for the Indian workforce.

"With nearly half of the workforce contemplating a career move over the next six months, enterprise resilience depends on looking far

beyond surface-level benefits. While many employers have made substantial progress, talent expectations are expanding faster than organisational structures can adapt," Narayan Iyer, MD,

Randstad India, said.

Iyer further noted that as India continues to attract global investment and expand its economic footprint, organisations that actively re-think their talent strategies will lead the market in talent attraction and retention.

"Ultimately, the future belongs to employers who master the art of making growth, flexibility, fairness, purpose, and reward coexist, rather than compete," he said.

This year's findings reveal that India's workforce is entering what can be described as the era of the

"Balanced Employer" — organisations that can simultaneously deliver meaningful work, career growth, inclusivity, wellbeing, flexibility and competitive rewards.

The survey further noted that performance recognition and career continuity, alongside reliable pay and benefits, are the strongest foundations of job security in India.

Across specialisations, expectations are broadly aligned, but digital talent stands apart: they prioritise competitive salary ahead of work-life balance, and are more likely to leave due to lack of career growth.

Auto, agri, processed food sectors to get export boost from UK CETA: Experts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The India-UK trade pact is expected to enhance market access for a range of domestic agricultural and processed food products through duty-free or preferential tariff treatment, and improve price competitiveness vis-a-vis suppliers from other countries in the British market, experts said.

The India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), which came into force on July 15, is also set to boost the automotive exports due to reduced tariffs, according to experts.

They said that for agriculture, the strongest opportunity lies in shifting export participation from commodity-led categories to value-added food products, as agri-food exports, including processed foods, stood at USD 49.43 billion in 2024-25 and accounted for around 11.2 per cent of India's total exports.

"The India-UK CETA is expected to improve market access through duty-free or preferential tariff treatment for a range of agricultural and processed food products, improving India's price competitiveness against non-FTA suppliers and supporting



diversification beyond traditional export destinations," Anand Ramanathan, Partner & Consumer Industry Leader, Deloitte South Asia, said.

He also said that the pact is likely to accelerate technology adoption across export-oriented agriculture, FPO-

linked supply chains and agritech suppliers because market access is increasingly tied to traceability, certification, quality assurance, and reliable delivery rather than tariffs alone.

Annual post-harvest losses are estimated at around Rs

92,651 crore, with cold-chain gaps across pack houses, ripening chambers, refrigerated transport, irradiation units and farm-gate pre-cooling acting as key constraints.

He added that digital technologies can directly address these gaps by improving traceability, reducing losses, supporting compliance and improving export reliability.

"Blockchain and IoT-based systems are especially relevant because food-sector competitiveness is moving toward batch-level visibility, temperature monitoring, supplier transaction records, predictive maintenance and real-

time supply-chain intelligence," Ramanathan said. Blockchain-enabled traceability platforms are being adopted to record batch movement, temperature exposure and supplier transactions.

About the impact of the pact on India's auto sector, Gulzar Didwania, Partner and Indirect Tax and India Global Trade Advisory Leader at Deloitte India, said the CETA is expected to provide a significant boost to India's automotive sector by improving export competitiveness while adopting a calibrated approach to import liberalisation.

EV industry to generate up to 40m jobs by 2030: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The electric vehicle (EV) sector is expected to create 30-40 million jobs by 2030, with hiring projected to grow 15-20 per cent annually, driven by rising demand for specialised talent in engineering, energy systems and battery technologies, a report said on Wednesday.

As EV adoption accelerates across passenger vehicles, commercial fleets, two-wheelers and public mobility, India's EV industry is entering its most employment-intensive phase, evolving from a vehicle manufacturing opportunity into a fully integrated industrial ecosystem,



according to the report by talent company Adecco India.

The EV sector is projected to generate 30-40 million jobs, with 10-15 per cent direct and 85-90 per cent indirect jobs by 2030, the report stated.

The report is based on insights from over 100 com-

panies in Adecco India's base.

According to the report, hiring is expected to grow by 15-20 per cent Y-o-Y, with the next decade defined less by assembly-line jobs and more by specialised engineering, energy systems and battery technologies across the value chain.

"India currently con-

tributes 4 per cent to the global EV industry in the passenger car segment and holds 17 per cent market share in 2-wheeler segment, but its long-term opportunity lies in capturing a far greater share of the global value chain.

"With states now operationalising execution-stage EV policies, including Delhi's ₹7,000-crore EV Policy 2026 and subsidy portal, India's EV story is shifting from incentive-driven adoption to industrial-scale hiring, making a critical inflection point for India's talent pipeline," Adecco India Director and Head of General Staffing Deepesh Gupta said.

RBI drafts new lending norms, protect borrowers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Reserve Bank on Wednesday proposed to rationalise the regulatory framework governing interest rates across all regulated entities to improve transparency in loan pricing, strengthen monetary policy transmission and bolster consumer protection.

The Reserve Bank proposes to rationalise the regulatory framework on interest rates for all regulated entities (REs) on a principle-based basis.

"To enhance transparency in lending rates and strengthen consumer protection, it is proposed to harmonise and standardise the regulatory framework on interest rates for all regulated entities," RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said while unveiling the third bi-monthly monetary policy review for the current fiscal.

The proposed rationalisation aims to harmonise the guidelines across REs while maintaining proportionality, address certain operational aspects of the current framework on MCLR and EBLR; and standardise certain divergent market practices concerning interest charging, including day count convention and benchmark reset dates, RBI said in its statement on Developmental and



Regulatory Policies.

These measures seek to ensure uniformity, enhance transparency in loan pricing, strengthen monetary transmission and bolster consumer protection.

Draft directions incorporating these proposals will be issued shortly for public comments, RBI said.

For better transparency, RBI directed banks to switch to external benchmarks like repo for loans from the earlier Marginal Cost of Funds framework in 2019.

Banks were asked to link all new floating-rate loans for housing, auto and MSMEs to an external benchmark like repo from October 1, 2019, with the objective to ensure faster transmission of policy rate cuts to borrowers.

The external benchmarks, to which banks are required to link their lending rates, could be repo, 3-month or 6-month treasury bill yield, or any other benchmark published by the Financial Benchmarks India Private Ltd (FBIL).

FROM THE WORLD

SRI LANKA

24 betting sites blocked

Sri Lanka has blocked access to 24 online gambling and betting websites operating without valid licences, the Government announced on Wednesday, as part of a crackdown on illegal online gambling. The move follows a notification issued by the Gambling Regulatory Authority to the Telecommunications Regulatory Commission of Sri Lanka, officials said. Following the notification, the commission directed all telecommunications service providers to restrict access to the 24 websites from within Sri Lanka with effect from August 4. Operating or promoting online gambling services in Sri Lanka without a valid licence issued under the Act is an offence. The Government urged the public not to participate in or invest money through illegal online gambling platforms. (PTI)

UK

Pak ex-minister arrested: Report

A former Pakistani state minister was arrested on sexual assault charges relating to young girls in the UK, but he contested an election in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) while on police bail, according to a British media report on Wednesday. Rukhsar Ahmed was reportedly "re-elected" in the PoK polls last week, after being out of office for five years. Ahmed was arrested at Manchester Airport back in July 2024 on suspicion of rape and trafficking children in care as part of a grooming gang scandal, The Guardian newspaper reported. "Ahmed was arrested at Manchester airport on 18 July 2024 in relation to past child sexual abuse allegations linked to the Rusholme area of the city, where he lived for many years," the report said. (PTI)

Bill aiming for Turkey-Kurdish peace goes to Parliament

SUZAN FRASER/ANDREW WILKS
■ Ankara

Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan's ruling party on Wednesday filed a bill in parliament to advance a peace initiative aimed at ending the decades-long conflict with Kurdish militants, including a provision for an effective pardon for former fighters. The Kurdistan Workers' Party, or PKK, last year declared its decision to disarm and disband as part of the peace effort with Turkey, following a call by its imprisoned leader, Abdullah Ocalan. The PKK then staged a symbolic disarmament ceremony in northern Iraq, where it is based, and announced that it was withdrawing fighters from key locations in Turkey to Iraq. The bill toward "strengthening national solidarity



and social cohesion" defines the procedures for overseeing the PKK's disarmament and the judicial treatment of its members. Parliament's Justice Committee on Friday will consider the bill before a debate in the general assembly, said Abdullah Gul, chair of the Justice and Development Party's parliamentary group. The Government hopes it passes before the summer recess later this month. "The critical threshold is the

surrender, disarmament and destruction of the PKK terrorist organisation's weapons and the establishment of a mechanism to determine this process," he told a news conference. The proposal was submitted with the support of 360 parliamentary deputies, Gul said, with more expected to sign up in the coming days. The PKK still has the bulk of its arsenal. A decommissioning mechanism will rely on confirmation by the National Security Council that the group has been disbanded and its weapons surrendered. The rehabilitation of PKK members is expected to include a pardon for about 4,000 members not directly involved in violence once the group is dissolved. This could pave the way for the release of people convicted of crimes such

as PKK membership or supporting the group financially or through propaganda. It will also allow the return of PKK members based in Syria and Iraq or in exile in European countries, Hurriyet newspaper reported. Ongoing investigations and prosecutions for such crimes would be postponed for a period dependent on the severity of the alleged offenses, Gul said. If no terror-related crime is committed within the time frame, the case will be dropped. Applications to benefit from the law must be made within six months of its publication in the Official Gazette, Gul said. A ministerial committee and a parliamentary commission will monitor the process. Militants convicted of intentional homicide and those sentenced to life sentences before

2005 are excluded from the bill's provisions. This applies to Ocalan and other senior PKK figures. The pro-Kurdish DEM Party has lobbied for Ocalan, who has been imprisoned since 1999, to be granted official status to coordinate the transition process, leading to his release. Although this is not in the current proposal, media reports suggest it may be considered later. Instead, Ocalan's situation in his island prison likely will be improved, giving him broader visiting conditions and communication with the outside world. The PKK has waged an armed insurgency since 1984, which has claimed tens of thousands of lives and spilled into Iraq and Syria. It has been designated a terrorist organisation by Turkey, the United States and the European Union. (AP)

Judge dismisses January seditious case, criticises justice department

ALANNA DURKIN RICHER ■ Washington

A federal judge decried efforts to rewrite the history of the January 6, 2021, attack on the Capitol as he reluctantly dismissed the seditious conspiracy case against members of the far-right Oath Keepers extremist group at the Trump administration's request. The move Tuesday closes the book on the January 6 cases that were wiped out with Republican President Donald Trump's sweeping pardons and commutations last year, freeing from prison people convicted of violent of assaults on police and other crimes. The Department of Justice in April acted to vacate the convictions of Oath Keepers founder Stewart Rhodes and others in the seditious conspiracy case who had their sentences commuted but did not receive



pardons. US District Judge Amit Mehta, who oversaw the Oath Keepers' trials, criticised the department's move, writing in his ruling that the Government "asks to absolve these Defendants of crimes against the United States itself." But Mehta wrote that he had no choice but to grant the administration's request. (AP)

EVA Air to launch nonstop Taipei-Delhi service

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Taipei

EVA Air will launch a new nonstop passenger service between Taipei and Delhi on December 1, 2026, marking a significant expansion of its South Asia network and making it the only Taiwan-based airline to operate nonstop passenger flights to India. Bookings for the new route are now open through EVA Air's website and authorized travel agencies. The service will operate five times a week using Airbus A330-300 aircraft. "The launch of nonstop Taipei-Delhi service represents an important milestone



in EVA Air's network development," said Clay Sun, President of EVA Air. "Growing connections across the manufacturing, semiconductor, artificial intelligence, and technology industries continue to drive closer economic ties between Taiwan and India. Our new Delhi route not only provides a more efficient travel option for business

and leisure passengers but also strengthens connectivity between India and North America through our Taipei hub." The new service is expected to improve travel convenience for passengers who currently rely on connections through other hubs. Through EVA Air's partnership with fellow Star Alliance member Air India, travelers arriving in Delhi will have access to seamless onward connections to major destinations across India. Likewise, passengers from India will be able to connect through Taipei to EVA Air's extensive North American network, serving growing demand from business travelers, students, researchers, and those visit-

ing family and friends. Eligible Indian nationals traveling to the United States or Canada may also benefit from Taiwan's conditional visa-waiver transit program, allowing easier stopovers in Taiwan while supporting inbound tourism. As India's political and commercial capital, Delhi also serves as the gateway to the country's renowned Golden Triangle tourism circuit, connecting Delhi, Agra, and Jaipur. In partnership with leading travel companies, EVA Air will offer six- to nine-day escorted tour packages featuring UNESCO World Heritage Sites, cultural attractions, premium accommodations, and Mandarin-speaking guides.

Spain, Ecuador target cocaine smuggling ring, make 44 arrests

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Spanish police on Wednesday said a multiyear investigation with Ecuadorian authorities to bust a drug smuggling ring led to 44 arrests and the confiscation of 21 tonnes of cocaine. The Civil Guard said the operation with Ecuador's National Police, which was overseen by Europol, targeted a ring that was financed by investors in Dubai and was smuggling drugs from South America into Spain in shipping containers. The first arrests were in March 2025, when Ecuadorian police detained 36 suspects and raided about 50 properties in that country, according to the Civil Guard. Spanish police then arrested eight suspects in raids on properties in Spain, confiscating 1 million euros (\$1.15 million).

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Mr. Rajinder Singh is the Possessor of the Property Bearing No. RZ - 02 - CA, measuring 125 sq. yards, comprising in Kharsa No. 177, situated at Colony known as Durga Park, Gali No. 1 in the Village Nasirpur, New Delhi - 110046. He is in Possession through Notarised GPA, Afs & Will dated 16.05.2001 executed by Mr. Pawan Kumar Gupta in favour of Mr. Rajinder Singh in respect of the Property Bearing No. RZ - 02 - CA, measuring 125 sq. yards, comprising in Kharsa No. 177.

PUBLIC NOTICE

General Public is hereby informed that my client Sh. Babu Singh S/o Diwan Singh R/o WZ-1477 Tara Chand Basti, Nangal Raya New Delhi-110046, Permanent Address: RZ-222, Gali No. 2, East Sagarpur, New Delhi-110046 and his wife Smt. Poonam have severed all their relations with their son Sh. Kapil Dev and his wife Annu. As they have gone out of control and have become disobedient therefore my clients hereby disown and debar their son and daughter-in-law from all their movable and immovable properties. Anybody dealing with Sh. Kapil Dev and Mrs. Annu will do so at his/her/their own risk and responsibility and my clients shall not be held responsible for any act, deed or dealing done with them.

Rajeev Kumar Malik & Associates (Advocate)
Ch. No. 99, Patiala House court, New Delhi-110001

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client Sh. Babu Singh, S/o Diwan Singh and his wife Smt. Poonam both R/o WZ-1477 Tara Chand Basti, Nangal Raya New Delhi-110046, Permanent Address: RZ-222, Gali No. 2, East Sagarpur, New Delhi-110046, vide general publication dated 08.06.2024 had severed all their relations with their son and debarred from all movable and immovable properties. General Public is hereby again informed that said Sh. Deepak Kumar and now his newly wedded wife Mrs. Diksha @ Saloni have again been disturbing the peaceful life of my clients continuously. My clients have not forgiven the misdeeds and such bad acts earlier and hereby again sever, disown and debar their son and daughter-in-law from all their movable and immovable properties. Anybody dealing with them will do so at his/her/their own risk and responsibility and my clients shall not be held responsible for any act, deed or dealing done with Sh. Deepak Kumar and daughter-in-law Diksha @ Saloni.

Rajeev Kumar Malik & Associates (Advocate)
Ch. No. 99, Patiala House court New Delhi-110001

South Africa pushes for Africa migration talks

MOGOMOTSI MAGOME
■ Johannesburg

The South African Governments pushing for Africa-wide talks while seeking to manage the fallout over anti-immigration protests that have forced many migrants to leave the country and caused diplomatic tensions with some its African counterparts.

The country has faced a backlash over protests calling for the deportation of migrants who are in the country illegally and reported violent attacks against migrants. But South African officials believe wider migration talks among all African nations could address the broader causes of the migration crisis throughout the continent as well as South Africa.

The African Union, which includes 55 member nations, rejected a proposal last week by Ghana to add South Africa's migration tensions to the agenda of the bloc's next coordination meeting in October. South Africa opposed the idea, protesting it would be



singled out without addressing the broader crisis. South Africa's divisive migration situation is expected to be discussed by national leaders later this month at a Southern African Development Community summit in South Africa, which is pushing for a broader discussion by all members of the African Union.

The countries expected at the talks in the South African city of Durban include Malawi, Mozambique and Zimbabwe, which have been repatriating some of their nationals from South Africa. (AP)

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client Ved Parkash S/o Karan Singh R/o Flat No. 88, Pkt-13, Sector-22, Rohini, Delhi-86 hereby declare that they have disowned and debarred his two son (1) Himanshu Yadav & his wife Twinkle (2) Mohit Yadav & his wife Tannu due to his misconduct and irresponsible behaviour, from my all movable and immovable properties. my client shall not be responsible for any act, transaction, debt etc. Any person dealing with him shall do so at his own risk and responsibility.

Shashikant (Advocate)
Ch. No. D-209, Karkardooma Courts, Delhi-32,

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that Share Certificate No. 831/17576-7578/29567/29963 for 600 equity shares each of Rs. 10/- (Rupees Ten Only) face value bearing Distinctive No.(S) 82371-82470/738071-738370/2976171-2976270/2976771-2976870 of M/S Titan Biotech Ltd for Folio No.0014558. Having its registered office at Beatal Financial & Computer Services (P) Limited Unit: Titan Biotech Ltd -3rd Floor, Beatal House, 98, behind Local Shopping Centre, Madangir Village, Madangir, New Delhi, Delhi 110062 Registered in the name of Amarjeet Kaur & Jastinder Singh have been lost. I have applied to the company for issue duplicate shares certificate. Any person who has any claim in respect of the said shares certificate should lodge such claim with the company within 15 days of the publication of this notice.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Sudesh Devi, W/o- JC- 473240N Sub Devi Dayal, R/o-Vill- Khanpur, Karamgarh, Dist- Jind, Haryana- 126116, have changed my name from Sudesh Devi to Sudesh Rani, vide affidavit dated 05/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, JC-473240N Sub Devi Dayal, R/o- Vill- Khanpur, Karamgarh, Dist- Jind, Haryana- 126116, have changed my son's name from Sachin to Sachin Jaglan, vide affidavit dated 05/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, JC-473489A Nb Sub Mukesh Singh, R/o- VPO- Hatheni, Dist- Bharatpur, Rajasthan- 321021, have changed my son's name from Khushal Singh to Khushhal Singh, vide affidavit dated 05/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Sahab Kauri W/o- No.2857622N Ex-Sep Sher Singh (Retd.), R/o- VPO- Jhamri, Teh- Matanahall, Dist- Jhajjar, Haryana- 124142, have changed my name from Sahab Kauri to Sahab Kaur, vide affidavit dated 05/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Balvir Singh, Father of JC-442401K Nb Sub Rakesh Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Kuloth Kalan, Teh- Chirawa, Dist- Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan- 333033, have changed my name from Balvir Singh to Balbir vide affidavit dated 05/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, B Gareya, Father of No.15753889W L/Nk Bunga Raju, R/o- At New Baxipalli, PO- Baxipalli, Dist- Ganjam, Odisha- 761002, have changed my name from B Gareya to B Garayya, vide affidavit dated 05/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

The Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer (Const), Northern Railway, Shivaji Bridge, New Delhi for and on behalf of the President of India invites open e-tender for the following work:-

- Name of work and location:** Electrical works in connection with conversion of New Ghaziabad Railway Station from Halt to Crossing Station, provision of Y-connection at Garhi Harsaru to avoid reversal of trains at Garhi Harsaru (2.5 km), and provision of a new Crossing Station 'JASIA' between ROK-GHNA Section of Northern Railway.
- Completion period of the work:** 12 months
- Approx. Cost of work:** Rs.72,56,452.40/-
- Bid Security to be deposited:** Rs. 1,45,200/-
- Date & Time for submission of E-tender and opening of tender:** Tenders may be uploaded upto 15:00 hrs on 27.08.2026 date on IREPS web site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in The bidders can participate in the e-tender, the tender will be opened at 15:00 hrs on 27.08.2026
- Detailed Tender Notice & Tender Document.** The detailed e-tender notice is available on Northern Railway web site i.e. www.nr.indianrailways.gov.in and tender document is available on www.ireps.gov.in Above tenders document will be available for submission of offer on IREPS web site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in from 13.08.2026 to 27.08.2026. All other terms and conditions in respect of above tenders are given in tender document.

The detailed tender notice also can be seen on the Notice Board of the above office.
Tender No. 17-Elect/DYCEE/Ct/1171 Dated: 05.08.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

2701/2026

BEFORE DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL-II, DELHI.

4TH FLOOR JEEVAN TARA BUILDING PARLIAMENT STREET NEW DELHI-110001.

Notice under section 19(4) of the Recovery of Debts Due to Bank and Financial Institutions Act 1993 read with rule 12 & 13 of the Debts Recovery Tribunal (Procedure Rule) 1993) in the matter of

OA NO 621/2022 **DATE: 18.06.2026**

JC FLOWERS ASSET RECON. PVT LTD INSTEAD OF YES BANK **APPLICANT**

VERSUS

THREE C PROPERTIES PVT LTD & ORS. **RESPONDENT**

To,

DEFENDANT

D3. LOTUS GREENS LLP
FLAT NO 14 GROUND FLOOR PULPEHLAD PUR DDA MIG SURAJ APARTMENT NEW DELHI-44

Whereas the above named applicant (s) has/have instituted a case for recovery of **Rs. 48,17,14,972.79 I/- (RUPEE FORTY EIGHT CRORE SEVENTEEN LAKH FORTY FOUR THOUSAND NINE HUNDRED SEVENTY TWO AND SEVENTY NINE PAISE ONLY)** against you and where as it has been shown to the satisfaction of the Tribunal that it is not possible to serve you in the ordinary way therefore, this notice is given by advertisement directing you to make appearance in the Tribunal on **17.08.2026 At 11.00 A.M.**

Take notice that in default of your appearance on the day before the mentioned, the case will be heard and determined in your absence.

All the matters will be taken up through video Conferencing or physical and for that purpose:-

(I) All the Advocates/Litigants shall download the "Cisco Webex" application/software:

(II) "Meeting ID" and Password for the date of hearing qua cases to be taken by Hon'ble Presiding Officer/ Registrar shall be displayed in the daily cause list itself at DRT Official Portal i.e. drt.gov.in

(III) In any exigency the Advocate/Litigants can contact the concerned official at **Ph. No. 23748478.**

Given under my hand and seal of the Tribunal this 18TH day of June., 2026

BY ORDER OF THE TRIBUNAL,
SECTION OFFICER, DRT-II, DELHI

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, प्रथम वृत्त,

लोकर निर्माण विभाग, अल्मोड़ा

ई-मेल: sepwdalm@rediffmail.com

पत्रांक : 2881 / निविदा-01 / 2026-27 दिनांक : 03 / 08 / 2026

राष्ट्रीय प्रतिस्पर्धात्मक ई-निविदा (E-Tendering) सूचना

मा० राज्यपाल महोदय, उत्तराखण्ड की ओर से अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, प्रथम वृत्त, ल०न०वि०. अल्मोड़ा द्वारा राज्य योजना के अन्तर्गत जनपद अल्मोड़ा के विधानसभा क्षेत्र सोमेश्वर के विकासखण्ड हवालबाग के अन्तर्गत कठपुड़िया – बंगसर मोटर मार्ग में डामरीकरण का कार्य की निविदा पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों/फर्मों जो उत्तराखण्ड के स्थाई निवासी हो, से दू बिड सिस्टम (Two Bid System) के अन्तर्गत ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से ऑनलाईन आमंत्रित की जाती है।

निविदाओं के विस्तृत विवरणों/संशोधनों/शुद्धि पत्रों/आदि को ई- प्रोक्योरमेन्ट पोर्टल <http://www.uktenders.gov.in> पर दिनांक 07 / 08 / 2026 के उपरान्त देखा जा सकता है।

अधीक्षण अभियन्ता

China retaliates against US with drone controls, sanctions

HUIZHONG WU/KANIS LEUNG
■ Bangkok

China announced a series of economic measures Wednesday against the United States, including controls on exports of drones to the US and a ban on dealings with six American entities, in response to recent restrictions imposed by Washington.

Tensions are simmering between the world's two biggest economies ahead of an expected visit by Chinese President Xi Jinping to the US in September, despite signs of warming ties during his meetings with US President Donald Trump in Beijing in May.

The Commerce Ministry said the sanctions are in response to recent moves from the US, including a ban by the US Federal Communications Commission on imports of Chinese drones, and the Department of Homeland Security's decision to add 43 Chinese companies to the Uyghur Forced Labour Prevention Act



entity list to prevent imports of goods made with forced labour.

The "measures seriously violate the important consensus reached by the two heads of state and severely damage China's legitimate rights and interests. China has no choice but to take necessary countermeasures in response," the ministry said in a statement. It emphasised that China was acting with restraint and urged the US to scrap its mea-

sures against Beijing and cease its "erroneous practices." It also warned of further sanctions if the US rolls out new restrictive measures against China.

Beijing is requiring reviews on a case-by-case basis of exports of unmanned aerial vehicles, their key components and related technologies that are on a list of export-controlled dual-use items that can serve both civilian and military purposes. (AP)

Taiwan kicks off military drills to counter potential Chinese attack

SIMINA MISTREANU ■ Taipei

Taiwan kicked off annual military exercises on Wednesday aimed at simulating a response to a potential Chinese invasion of the self-governed island, which Beijing claims as its own.

The live-fire exercises will test the Taiwanese army's ability to sustain 24-hour defence operations as well as counter China's "grey-zone tactics," which stop just short of open warfare. Urban resilience drills will test the population's response to a disruption in internet service.

The 10-day Han Kuang exercises are set to be held in various locations around the island. This year's drills will test new, US-inspired communication methods, including backbriefs — where subordinates explain to commanders how they plan to carry out assigned missions. The communication drills are intended to encourage first-line fighters to be more self-reliant and effective in battle, experts say. Another focus of this year's drills is



that they will mobilise the largest ever team of reservists, more than 5,000 service members across two brigades. Last year's drills involved one brigade of more than 3,000 reservists.

The drills will test how quickly reserves can mobilise from peacetime standby mode to full active duty.

Another focus of the exercises, reflecting Taiwan's longstanding emphasis on civil defence, is urban resilience drills. These will take place on different days in the major cities of Kaohsiung, Taichung and the Capital, Taipei. (AP)

Russian missile and drone barrage in Ukrainian Capital region kills 17

HANNA ARHIROVA ■ Kyiv

Russian missile and drone strikes on Kyiv and the surrounding region killed 17 people and wounded 44 others overnight into Wednesday, smashing business premises and a train station, Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said.

The targets hit included a brewing company, a warehouse for construction material and a mail sorting office that had nothing to do with the war, Zelenskyy said. But the Russian Defence Ministry said the businesses masked ties to the military.

The nighttime attack lasting about two hours was the latest in a series of large-scale Russian ballistic missile strikes that have become near-routine this summer.

The intensified barrages are exploiting Ukraine's critical shortage of interceptor missiles for the US-made Patriot systems, the sole air defence weapon in its arsenal able to shoot down ballistic missiles. Zelenskyy has pleaded with other countries to send more of the ammunition made scarcer by the Iran war.

Supplies of air defence missiles to Ukraine during



A postal worker clearing the debris at the damaged Nova Poshta postal warehouse after Russian missiles strikes in Kyiv, Ukraine

the first half of this year tumbled to one-third of the 2025 level, Zelenskyy said.

"Ballistic interceptors are what could have saved the lives of those killed today,"

Zelenskyy said on social media. "It is very important for our partners to understand that delays in supplying them, or a reluctance to hand over anti-ballistic systems, lead directly to such horrific casualties and destruction."

With US-led peace efforts apparently stalled, Ukraine has stepped up its deep strikes on key Russian targets such as oil refineries in an effort to compel Russian President Vladimir Putin to negotiate.

Zelenskyy has accepted an unconditional ceasefire demanded by US President Donald Trump but Putin has

refused. In its latest attack on logistics facilities of Wildberries, Russia's biggest online retailer, Ukrainian drones hit a warehouse in the Tula region south of Moscow, the company and the region's governor said on Wednesday.

It was the 14th Wildberries warehouse to catch fire in less than three weeks, according to a Ukrainian tally. Ukraine says the company provides goods that can be used by the military. Kyiv is also keen to unsettle the Russian public with high-profile attacks. (AP)

Rising temperatures could keep more flights from taking off on time

RIO YAMAT/ MK WILDEMAN
■ Las Vegas

Airline passengers know to expect possible flight delays when weather forecasts call for thunderstorms, heavy snow or strong wind. The omens are less obvious on a hot summer day with clear skies.

Yet extreme heat also disrupts flights and travel plans. On the hottest days, thinner air can make it harder for aircraft to get off the ground safely. Airlines may have to lighten the load by removing passengers or cargo, or carrying less fuel.

The snag is well known at airports in desert climates around the world, from the US Southwest to the Middle East. But even less extreme heat can create similar challenges at airports with higher elevations or shorter runways. Researchers say human-caused climate change could make such disruptions more common.

With heat waves searing parts of the United States and Europe this summer, Las Vegas illustrated how extreme heat can interfere with air travel. American Airlines offered compensation to customers who voluntarily gave up their seats on



a July 24 flight from Harry Reid International Airport after temperatures reached 114 degrees Fahrenheit (47 degrees Celsius).

The airline described reducing a plane's weight as a standard industry practice in hot-weather destinations when conditions require it to ensure a safe takeoff. The explanation comes down to physics.

Hot air is thinner than cool air, making it harder for a plane's wings to generate lift and for jet engines to generate the thrust needed for takeoff, explained Ross Aimer, a retired United Airlines captain and CEO of Aero Consulting Experts.

"There is a science behind all this," Aimer said. "You can't deny the science of flight and what it takes for an airplane to operate." (AP)

FS Misri meets Lanka's top leadership

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri on Wednesday met Sri Lanka's top leadership and discussed issues of mutual interest and reviewed key bilateral projects, including Indian-assisted development projects in the island nation.

Misri, who arrived in Colombo for a day-long visit, called on President Anura Kumara Dissanayake in Colombo. Their "discussions focused on issues of mutual interest and review of key bilateral projects, including India-assisted development projects in Sri Lanka," the Indian High Commission in Colombo said in a post on X.

"Following the meeting, both sides exchanged agreements on INR-denominated Lines of Credit for USD



Vikram Misri meets Vijitha Herath

350 mn, which form part of the \$450 mn reconstruction package extended by India in the wake of Cyclone Ditwah.

The LoCs will support reconstruction, infrastructure development, and procurement requirements that arose in the aftermath of the cyclone," it said. Misri also held a meeting with Foreign

Minister Vijitha Herath during which they reviewed ongoing cooperation in key priority areas.

He is also scheduled to meet Prime Minister Harini Amarasuriya.

Foreign Secretary Misri also met his Sri Lankan counterpart Aruni Nanaraja and "discussed regional and global issues of mutual interest, and ways to further deepen close bilateral ties," the Indian mission said.

Misri reinforced Sri Lanka's central role in India's Neighbourhood First Policy and in advancing Vision MAHASAGAR. Misri, who arrived in Colombo to further strengthen the longstanding partnership between the two countries, was received at the airport by the Indian High Commissioner Santosh Jha and senior officials from the Sri Lankan Ministry.

Record heat wave impacts people and animals in Japan, Korean peninsula

HYUNG-JIN KIM/ MARI YAMAGUCHI ■ Seoul

Fans fainting at a baseball park. Lions dying at a zoo. A woman taking shelter in a car found dead. A doctor advising people to eat dog meat to promote stamina.

The scenes caused by a record heat wave in Northeast Asia illustrate how extreme temperatures have gripped South Korea, North Korea and Japan. In most of South Korea, a major heat wave advisory was in place Wednesday as temperatures in densely populated greater Seoul, home to 20 million



people, and adjacent areas soared as high as 39 degrees Celsius (102.2 degrees Fahrenheit). North Korean authorities have issued a heat wave advisory in many

areas and called for people to take safety steps to avoid heat-related health problems. Japan's anti-disaster agency reported more than 18,000 people with heat

stroke symptoms were transported to hospitals during the week of July 20 to 26.

Since mid-May in South Korea, about 2,220 people have been diagnosed with heat-related illnesses and 19 have died, according to a report from Interior and Safety Ministry. About 17,140 livestock, such as chickens, ducks and pigs, and about 160,000 farmed fishes also have died.

On Sunday, the southeastern city of Yangsan saw temperatures reaching 42.5 Celsius (108.5 Fahrenheit), the highest figure recorded since weather observation

began in Korea in 1904.

In a Cabinet meeting Tuesday, President Lee Jae Myung instructed officials to view the ongoing heat wave as "a national disaster" and make all-out efforts to protect lives.

On Tuesday night, a spectator in his 20s collapsed while watching a baseball game between SSG Landers and LG Twins at a stadium in Incheon city, west of Seoul. Emergency personnel administered CPR and transported him to a hospital, halting the game for about 10 minutes. Another fan in his 20s fell unconscious and

received treatment at the stadium after the game, according to the Korea Baseball Organization, which announced Wednesday that all 10 games scheduled for Wednesday and Thursday were cancelled and would be rescheduled.

Min Son Yong, deputy director of the internal medicine department at Pyongyang General Hospital, told North Korea's main Rodong Sinmun newspaper on Sunday that people should eat dog meat and fish porridge to supplement protein to beat the heat. (AP)

Bangladesh turns ousted Hasina's official residence into museum

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

Amid tightened nationwide security, Bangladesh on Wednesday inaugurated a memorial museum to commemorate the victims of violence during the anti-government protests in 2024 that toppled Sheikh Hasina's Government.

Prime Minister Tarique Rahman inaugurated the 'July Mass Uprising Memorial Museum' at Ganabhaban, prime minister's official residence during Hasina's regime, coinciding with the day she fled to India on August 5, 2024.

"The killers in the anti-fascist movement will be tried in a transparent, impartial and credible manner following the due process of law," Rahman said in a brief



Bangladesh's Prime Minister Tarique Rahman and former interim leader Muhammad Yunus arriving for the inauguration of a museum at the former residence of Bangladesh's ousted leader Sheikh Hasina in Dhaka

address while unveiling the museum's plaque.

"Justice for every crime is essential to ensure rule of law" Rahman said as the Interim government chief Muhammad

Yunus stood beside him. The prime minister announced that government institutions would be named after slain activists of the uprising and those who were killed during

the rule of Hasina's Awami League since 2009.

According to a February 2025 UN rights office report, up to 1,400 people were killed between July 15 and August 15

last year, the period dubbed as the 'July Uprising,' as Hasina's government ordered a security crackdown on protesters. Three days after Hasina fled to India following the widespread protests against her government over a controversial quota system in jobs, Yunus took over as the chief adviser of the Interim government.

A special tribunal set up by Yunus' government gave Hasina a death sentence in November 2025 on charges of "crimes against humanity" and "genocide." His interim regime, under an executive order, also banned Hasina's Awami League that has been in power for many terms since 1971. The decision was endorsed by Rahman's Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) government after the February 12 elections.

Fauci's decision to invoke Fifth Amendment tees up legal debate

ERIC TUCKER ■ Washington

Dr Anthony Fauci's decision to invoke the Fifth Amendment before Congress will be put to the test this week as a Republican-led committee prepares to vote to hold him in contempt and refer the matter to the Justice Department.

A contempt finding could open the door to an investigation into whether Fauci had a valid constitutional right against self-incrimination when he refused to answer dozens of questions from lawmakers at a committee hearing last week focused on his handling of the COVID-19 pandemic.

Republican senators including Rand Paul of Kentucky, who subpoenaed Fauci and has called a contempt vote for Thursday, insist that a pardon the doctor received early last year from Democratic President Joe Biden left him ineligible for Fifth Amendment protections. A Senate resolution released Tuesday asserts that Paul found Fauci's privilege claims "unsupported." But some legal experts say Fauci had reasons to invoke the



Fifth Amendment, given the threat of potential state prosecutions and questions from President Donald Trump's administration about the validity of Biden's pardons. Any testimony from Fauci could have also prompted false-statement investigations like the ones the current Justice Department has repeatedly initiated against the Republican president's perceived adversaries.

No matter what happens, the episode raises fresh and complicated questions about Congress' ability to compel testimony from previously pardoned witnesses — and the outcome could resonate beyond Fauci. (AP)

SpaceX posts loss in first report as public company



BERNARD CONDON
■ New York

SpaceX reported it lost more than half a billion dollars in its first quarterly report as a public company, but the loss was less than Wall Street expected and revenue soared.

The company run by Elon Musk reported a loss of \$541 million, or 9 cents per share, in the three months through June, less than half what financial analysts had expected. Revenue jumped to \$7.8 billion, up more than 90 per cent from the year-earlier period.

Musk will field questions from investors and financial analysts soon on a conference call. Stock in the rocket, satellite communications and AI company has fallen by roughly half since its June peak, shortly after an initial

public offering that briefly made Musk the world's first trillionaire.

Investors have knocked the share price down on worries Musk had oversold them on the company's future prospects for space travel and colonisation among other issues. They are also bracing for volatile trading as some company insiders get the opportunity to sell shares after the expiration of what is known as a lockup provision later in the week.

The shares jumped 19 per cent on their first day of trading, making Musk the first-ever trillionaire. The subsequent drop in SpaceX, as well as a decline in the shares of Musk's electric vehicle company Tesla, have knocked his wealth down to \$783 billion, according to Forbes. (AP)

Trump administration revokes visa of Brazil's ambassador



MATTHEW LEE/MAURICIO SAVARESE ■ Washington

The Trump administration has revoked the visa of Brazil's ambassador to the United States in retaliation for Brazil's denial of visas last month for two American diplomats who sought to visit ahead of upcoming elections as well as Brazil's stalling on approving President Donald Trump's nominee to be ambassador in Brasilia. The State Department said the decision was a reciprocal response to Brazil's actions and officials said the step had been delayed several times to give Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva room to back down,

something he did not do. Officials said, however, that it could be quickly reversed if Brazil takes appropriate action and accepts Trump's ambassadorial choice.

Trump has had a fractious relationship for some time with Lula's administration, which has opposed him on numerous policies, particularly in the Western Hemisphere regarding Venezuela and Cuba. Their relationship also has been strained by Trump's fondness for Lula's first-term successor and then predecessor, Jair Bolsonaro, who is currently under house arrest, and his son Flavio, who is Lula's main opponent in the October election. (AP)

➤ PROSPECT

IGDTUW launches BTech in Computer Science & Engineering (Cyber Security)

Reinforcing its commitment to academic excellence and technological innovation, Indira Gandhi Delhi Technical University for Women (IGDTUW) has launched a new BTech. programme in Computer Science & Engineering (Cyber Security) from the Academic Session 2026-27. The programme has been introduced in response to the rapidly growing demand for skilled professionals who can protect the nation's digital infrastructure and address emerging cyber threats. It has an approved intake of 77 students through JAC Delhi admissions.



With the rapid expansion of Artificial Intelligence, cloud computing, digital payments, smart manufacturing, IoT, e-governance and critical infrastructure, cyber security has become one of the most sought-after domains worldwide. Governments, multinational corporations, financial institutions, defence organisations, healthcare systems and technology companies are increasingly investing in cyber resilience, creating unprecedented career opportunities for professionals in this field.

(PNS)

NHPC seeks shareholders nod to raise borrowing limit to ₹70,000 crore

State-owned hydropower giant NHPC will seek shareholders' approval to raise its borrowing limit from ₹60,000 crore to ₹70,000 crore at the annual general meeting scheduled on August 28, 2026.



On the need for the proposed increase in borrowing limit, the company explained in the notice for the AGM that, keeping in view fund requirements due to the very robust capex plan of the company, the limit of ₹60,000 crore is required to be increased. The tentative debt requirement for ongoing and new projects up to about the next five years as per capex requirements will be approximately ₹67,500 crore, which will exceed the approved borrowing limit of ₹ 60,000 crore in about the next three years, it stated. The approval of the shareholders is being sought by way of special resolution, for authorising the Board of Directors to borrow money from time to time, exceeding the paid-up share capital, its free reserves and securities premium, provided that total amount so borrowed (apart from the temporary loans obtained from the bankers of the company in the ordinary course of business) shall not at any time exceed ₹70,000 crore.

(PNS)

NBCC bags ₹780 cr project in Andhra Pradesh from RBI

State-owned NBCC Ltd has bagged a ₹780 crore contract from the Reserve Bank of India to build an office complex and staff quarters in Andhra Pradesh. In a regulatory filing on Wednesday, the company informed that NBCC has secured a work order from the RBI worth ₹780.38 crore.

NBCC will be the PMC (project management consultancy) for the construction of the office complex of the RBI at Nelapadu, Amaravati, Andhra Pradesh, and also its officers' and staff residential complex at Inavolu, Amaravati. The company is into PMC and real estate businesses.

(PNS)

Lok Sabha passes Bankers' Books Evidence Bill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Lok Sabha on Wednesday passed a Bill to replace a British-era legislation with the objective of including digital and virtual records as admissible evidence in the court of law in sync with the digital dependence of the banking system.

As soon as the House reassembled at 2 pm after an earlier adjournment, the opposition members continued with their sloganeering, refusing to heed the pleas of the Chair to discuss the Bankers' Books Evidence Bill, 2026. The Bill was moved by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman for consideration and passage amid din.



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in the Lok Sabha during the Monsoon session of Parliament in New Delhi

(PTI)

(instead of physical record). It has, therefore, become necessary to modernise and strengthen the existing legal framework to meet the requirements of the present banking system," the state-

ment of objects and reasons of the Bill said.

The Bill proposes to expand the scope of the definition of "bankers' books" to include all forms of records maintained by banks,

whether in physical, electronic, digital, virtual, cloud-based or in any other form, thereby providing a comprehensive, technology-neutral and future-ready legal framework, it said.

It proposes to provide for standardised certificate formats and authentication by manual or digital or electronic signature and to expressly recognise admissibility of electronic bank records and permit their production in either physical or electronic form.

It is also going to empower the central government to extend applicability of the proposed legislation to any entity or class of entities operating in the financial sector, subject to certain

conditions, it said. The Bill seeks to define the expression "special cause", for which a court may, by order in writing, compel an officer of the bank to produce any bankers' books or to appear as witness to prove matters, transactions or accounts, in any legal proceeding where the bank is not a party.

The Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 1891 was enacted during the pre-independence era to facilitate the use of certified copies of bank records as evidence in legal proceedings without requiring the production of the original records.

It was enacted at a time when banking records were predominantly maintained in physical form.

CM Saini discusses AI, data-driven governance with World Bank team

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Wednesday held a meeting with a delegation of the World Bank in Chandigarh and discussed in detail ways to give a new direction to Artificial Intelligence (AI), digital governance, skill development and data-driven administration in the State.

The Chief Minister said that Haryana does not want to limit technology merely to innovation; rather, the government's objective is to ensure that its benefits reach the common citizen directly. He said that technology is meaningful only when it makes people's lives easier and makes government services more transparent, faster and more effective.

During the meeting, World Bank officials informed the Chief Minister that the AI Sandbox developed by the World Bank in collaboration with the Haryana Government will be showcased on the global stage at the Korea Digital Summit, to be held in Korea from October 19 to 22. IT ministers and digital sector experts from across the world will be apprised of its achievements during the summit. World Bank officials also invited Chief Minister Sh. Nayab Singh Saini to participate in the summit.



The Chief Minister described the Parivar Pehchan Patra (PPP) as one of the state's most important digital initiatives and said that it is enabling eligible beneficiaries to receive the benefits of government schemes in a timely and transparent manner. He said that several states across the country are studying this model. Keeping in view the needs of the times, PPP 2.0 will now be developed to make it more modern and user-friendly.

He said that Haryana intends to move forward towards seamless exchange of information among various departments by developing a comprehensive Data Exchange Policy and Data Lake. This will make policy formulation and administrative decision-making more accurate and effective.

The Chief Minister urged the World Bank to expedite the launch of the Haryana AI and Development Project and said that the proposed AI

Gurukul under the project would equip youth with skills aligned with future requirements. Special focus would also be laid on training as per industry requirements and developing skill centres in every district.

During the meeting, the Chief Minister also suggested developing a dedicated AI model for Haryana. He said that this model, by understanding the state's laws, rules and government procedures, would help officials take quick and accurate decisions and provide citizens with faster, simpler and quality services.

The Chief Minister requested the World Bank's cooperation in developing an Air Quality Decision Support System to make air quality management in the state more effective.

He said that officials who recently returned from a study tour of China had shared information about the modern systems being adopted there.

Minister Kaushik Rai steps up efforts to prevent urban flooding in Guwahati

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Kaushik Rai today chaired a high-level review meeting with senior officials of the Department of Housing & Urban Affairs to assess the prevailing flood situation in Greater Guwahati and the National Highways passing through the city.

The meeting was attended by the Commissioner & Secretary and Secretary of the Department of Housing & Urban Affairs, the Chief Executive Officer of GMDA, the Commissioner of GMC, the Commissioner & Special Secretary of the Public Works Roads Department (PWRD), officials of the National



Highways Authority of India (NHAI), and other concerned departments.

During the meeting, the Minister reviewed the progress made on the decisions taken in the previous review meeting and assessed the status of the ongoing flood mitigation measures.

Detailed discussions were held on the effective deployment of the Super Sucker by the Guwahati Municipal Corporation (GMC), resec-

tioning and redesigning of culverts along the National Highways, desiltation of drains, improvement of the drainage network, and other engineering interventions aimed at enhancing stormwater management across the city.

Emphasising the need for a sustainable solution to Guwahati's recurring urban flooding, Rai directed the concerned departments to prepare a comprehensive masterplan for systematic cleaning and maintenance of the city's drainage network well ahead of the monsoon season every year. He stressed that preventive measures and scientific planning must form the cornerstone of the city's long-term flood management strategy.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Kaushik Rai today chaired a high-level review meeting with senior officials of the Department of Housing & Urban Affairs to assess the prevailing flood situation in Greater Guwahati and the National Highways passing through the city.

The meeting was attended by the Commissioner & Secretary and Secretary of the Department of Housing & Urban Affairs, the Chief Executive Officer of GMDA, the Commissioner of GMC, the Commissioner & Special Secretary of the Public Works Roads Department (PWRD), officials of the National

GROWTH across INDUSTRY

 भारत हेवी इलेक्ट्रिकल्स लिमिटेड
Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited

62nd वार्षिक आम बैठक
Annual General Meeting

बुधवार, 05 अगस्त 2026 | Wednesday, 05th August 2026



K Sadashiv Murthy, Chairman & Managing Director, BHEL, addressed shareholders through video conferencing at the company's 62nd Annual General Meeting, in the presence of the Board of Directors of the company, in New Delhi on Wednesday

DAILY SUDOKU

	3					7		
7					5		2	4
		5	2	7				
			7				8	
3	7					1		6
	4				9			
				3	6	9		
4	1		9					2
	8						6	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (5.8.26)

2	1	5	3	4	6	9	8	7
3	4	9	5	8	7	2	1	6
8	7	6	1	2	9	4	3	5
5	3	4	9	1	8	6	7	2
7	9	2	6	3	5	1	4	8
1	6	8	2	7	4	5	9	3
9	2	7	4	6	3	8	5	1
4	8	1	7	5	2	3	6	9
6	5	3	8	9	1	7	2	4

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

THURSDAY | AUGUST 6, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6
7					
10	11	12		13	
14			15		16
	21			22	
23			24		25
26			27	28	
				29	30
34					
			35		
36					

ACROSS

4 Looks at books (6)

7 Foreign confectionery to have a filing with (8)

8 A trap's reset in an ancient city (6)

10 A private name (5)

13 One can weaken and still wave it (4)

14 It didn't grow at Tyburn (4)

15 Coastal feature ripe for redevelopment (4)

16 A familiar facsimile (3)

17 On the ground, perhaps, too weak to stand up? (4)

19 A figure advanced at Bristol, for instance (4)

DOWN

1 Writer of Caledonian tales initially (5)

2 He's imagined to make men go astray (5)

3 Light? Emphatically! (4)

4 Passage to a place like Capri (5)

5 Many a student joke is a bore (4)

6 He gave a perfect ending to a clever piece of painting (6)

9 Show proudly that dad's exceptionally dear (6)

11 A royal ball (3)

12 Over a yard, but just about a quarter of a foot! (5)

13 The one Madame Butterfly sang of? (4,3)

21 Actor playing Bonnie Prince Charlie? (9)

23 By which Elsie is no end misled? (4)

24 Passes for females (4)

26 Fail to survive on an inadequate diet (3)

27 To some ladies, an unpleasant creature (4)

29 But a greyhound can get out of it (4)

32 Blue essay about love (4)

33 Old African country with a middle-sized river (5)

34 In play, could be termed a city of gentlemen (6)

35 The cat gets a bird – as it flies through the air? (8)

36 One learning the way in N. Ireland? (6)

15 Mine's in hospital (3)

16 In favour of raising the roof, nothing less (3)

18 Charlton, in the London area (6)

20 She can be strikingly enlightening (5)

21 Soft, that is, to eat? (3)

22 Seem ready to drop off (3)

23 Brownish uniform? (6)

25 Heart to heart listener (3)

28 Are to edit and deliver a speech (5)

30 Figure a liar may be out to surpass you! (6)

31 Not exactly perky, but rather sickly (5)

32 Common verb that turns up in Herodotus (2,2)

33 Laze around with gusto! (4)

SOLUTION (5.8.26)

ACROSS	22, Libel	DOWN	1, Conger	19, CAB
1, Circle	23, Boys	2, Chale-t	20, A-LL	21, Tigress
7, Dia-tribe	26, Sprig	3, Edge		
8, Pa-NG	28, Bar	4, Start-le		
10, Grief	29, Oth-er-s	5, Clear		
11, Urban-E	30, Willow	6, L-even		
14, Eel	31, Ably	8, P-ep		
16, Tur-i-n	32, Van-i-shed	9, Nil		
17, RA-PT	33, Ending	12, Bus (lane)		
19, C-alls		13, N-ft-Y		
21, Table		15, Nobel		
		18, Ad-opt		
		25, SE-wing		
		26, Solve		
		27, Rhi-no		
		28, Sib		
		30, Wade		

Alaboi Ron Smriti Divas observed in Kamrup

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The 357th martyrdom anniversary of the brave Ahom warriors who laid down their lives during the historic Battle of Alaboi was observed with due solemnity on Wednesday as Alaboi Ron Smriti Divas at Amingaon. The programme was organised by the Directorate of Archaeology, Assam, in collaboration with the Indigenous and Tribal Faith and Culture Department, Kamrup District Administration, and the Saraihat Journalists' Forum.



The programme commenced with the offering of floral tributes and the lighting of ceremonial lamps at the Alaboi Ron Smriti Soudh, located in front of the Office of the District Commissioner, Kamrup, in memory of the brave Ahom soldiers who laid down their lives while defending the motherland during the historic Battle of

Alaboi on August 5, 1669.

Prakash Chandra Das, MLA, Hajo-Sualkuchi, expressed gratitude to the Chief Minister of Assam for bringing the Battle of Alaboi and the sacrifices of the Ahom martyrs into greater public focus.

Diganta Kalita, MLA, Kamalpur, emphasised the importance of educating the younger generation about the glorious history of the Battle of Alaboi and the unparalleled sacrifice of the Ahom martyrs. He observed that the district-level observance of Alaboi

Directorate of Archaeology, Assam, highlighted the historical significance of the Battle of Alaboi and emphasised the importance of preserving and promoting Assam's rich historical heritage for future generations.

In his address, Deba Kumar Mishra, District Commissioner, Kamrup, paid rich tributes to the Ahom martyrs and described the Battle of Alaboi as one of the defining chapters in Assam's history.

JITF INFRALOGISTICS LIMITED

CIN NO. : L60231CT2008PLC016434

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NOTICE OF THE 19th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

Notice is hereby given that the 19th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Company will be held on **Tuesday, 1st September 2026 at 12.30 P.M.** at Hotel Grand Rajputana, Telghani Naka Chowk, Station Road, Raipur-492001, Chhattisgarh to transact the business as set out in the Notice convening the said Annual General Meeting. The Notice of AGM along with Annual Report for the Financial Year ended 31st March 2026 has been sent to the members who hold shares as on record date, i.e., 31st July 2026, by email, whose email id is registered with the Company/Depository(s) and the physical copy to all the other members. The said documents can also be viewed on the company's website at www.jitfinfra.com.

Notice is also hereby given that pursuant to section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 and regulation 42 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the Register of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Company shall remain closed from 25th August 2026 to 1st September 2026 (both days inclusive) for the purpose of AGM.

Further, pursuant to the provisions of section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with rule 20 of Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 and regulation 44 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the Company is providing remote e-voting facility to its members to cast their vote electronically on the resolutions to be transacted at 19th AGM of the Company.

The member please note the following:

a. The remote e-voting shall commence at 9.00 a.m. on Saturday, 29th August 2026 and shall end at 5.00 p.m. on Monday, 31st August 2026.

b. The remote e-voting shall not be available beyond 5.00 p.m. on Monday, 31st August 2026.

c. The cut-off date for determining the eligibility of members for remote e-voting and voting through poll at AGM is 25th August 2026.

d. Any person who becomes member of the Company after dispatch of notice of the meeting and holding shares as on cut-off date i.e. 25th August 2026, may obtain the user id and password by contacting RCMC Shares Registry (Pvt.) Ltd., R & T Agent of the Company at B-25/1, Okhla Industrial Area Phase II, New Delhi – 110020, phone-011-26387320-21, Fax-011-26387322, Email- evoting.services@rcmcindia.com.

e. The members who cast their vote through remote e-voting may also attend the AGM but shall not be allowed to cast their vote at AGM.

f. The facility of voting through poll shall be available at the AGM to those members who have not casted their vote through remote e-voting.

g. Members may go through the e-voting instructions provided in the AGM Notice or visit <https://evoting.nsdl.com> and in case of any queries, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for members and e-voting User Manual for members available at the download section of <https://evoting.nsdl.com>.

For JITF Infra Logistics Limited

Sd/-

Alok Kumar

Company Secretary

ACS-19819

Place: New Delhi

Date: 05.08.2026

BRIEFLY

European leagues add to pressure on Infantino amid crisis meeting



The association of European soccer leagues called for governance reform of FIFA on Wednesday, adding to the mounting pressure on president Gianni Infantino following his failed plan to sell stakes in the World Cup.

On the day that Infantino reportedly held a meeting with senior staff in Rabat, Morocco, European Leagues, which includes top competitions like the Premier League, La Liga and Serie A, described the proposal as "dangerous" and said it pointed to deeper concerns about how world soccer's governing body operates. It said it raised "serious questions about FIFA's governance, internal culture and decision-making." "Now more than ever, FIFA requires governance reform that ensures that all relevant stakeholders have a formal role in decisions that shape the future of our game."

In the statement European Leagues hit out at the possibility of further expanding the World Cup to 64 teams and said "FIFA must not be allowed to continue taking unilaterally disruptive decisions." It said that until there was reform it would reject the "expansion or creation" of FIFA competitions.

European Leagues is latest to condemn Infantino's plans after a tumultuous week, which has raised questions about his presidency of FIFA ahead of elections in March. (AP)

Shubhankar, Anirban to lead DP World India Challenge



Shubhankar Sharma and Anirban Lahiri will spearhead the Indian challenge against a world-class field featuring Major winner Rory McIlroy, and defending champion Tommy Fleetwood among others at the DP World India Championship, to be held at the picturesque Delhi Golf Club from October 15 to 18.

The USD four million tournament is the eighth of nine events in the Back 9 phase of the 2026 Race to Dubai and serves as a key stop on the road to the season-ending DP World Tour Play-offs, culminating in the DP World Tour Championship in Dubai in November.

Sharma and Lahiri will be joined by an elite international field that also includes and reigning Open champion Ryan Fox, Shane Lowry, Justin Rose, European Ryder Cup captain Luke Donald and Ryder Cup star Viktor Hovland. (PTI)

Diksha, Pranavi and Aditi all set for PIF London Championships



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ London

Golfers Diksha Dagar and Aditi Ashok, along with two others, will tee off at the \$2 million PIF London Championship on the Ladies European Tour as it enters final week of its UK swing on Thursday. Diksha, who has been enjoying a good season on the Tour, is still searching for her third LET title while also aiming to better her career-best finish on the Tour.

She has recorded a string of top-10 finishes and is currently eighth on the Order of Merit, having finished in

the top three in 2023.

Aditi is also in the field as she continues to split her schedule between the LPGA Tour and the LET. The five-time LET winner, who is yet to register a victory on LPGA Tour, has produced modest results this season and will be looking to change that this week. Joining the duo are Avani Prashanth and Pranavi Urs, whose recent results have been encouraging. It is the sixth consecutive year that Centurion Club in Hertfordshire is hosting the tournament, which will feature a field of 120 players. (PTI)

CWG review: Some concerns but positives too for ministry

POONAM MEHRA ■ New Delhi

It threw up challenges, both sporting and administrative, validated major plans but also highlighted the need to course correct in few aspects. The just-concluded Commonwealth Games was akin to a mid-term exam for the Sports Authority of India (SAI).

The nodal body under the Sports Ministry that is responsible for conducting national camps, overseeing selection, and monitoring the training and competition calendar of athletes, is celebrating the "more than expected" medal count of 39, which includes 13 gold and 17 silver medals.

At the same time, its push for greater support to swimming and cycling got a reality check at the Games thanks to medal-less and underwhelming show.

In addition, logistical issues such as boxers and judo players not receiving their baggage on time after arriving in Glasgow have been noted as administrative concerns to be addressed going forward.

"The brightest aspect of this tally is the judo performance (two gold, one silver and one bronze). Yes, swimming and cycling remain work in progress and it is still



time before we become truly competitive. Boxing is another positive. You might say the competition shrunk this time but that's not our fault. We fight whoever is in front of us," acknowledged a senior SAI official.

"In weightlifting we should have got maybe two gold medals instead of one (Mirabai Chanu)."

India participated in 12 judo events in Glasgow and won four medals — two gold, one silver and one bronze, compared to three medals, minus any gold, in 2022. This was despite the fact that a couple of judokas had to be withdrawn due to a n t i - d o p i n g offences prior to the team's departure.

The boxing contingent topped the medal tally with a haul of 10 medals, including seven gold and three silver.

"There are some administrative issues as well. Some course correction is needed on that front, like athletes not receiving their baggage. Perhaps it would be a good idea to have a points person with team, specifically instructed to handle these things in future Games," official said. (PTI)



CWG gold medallist para athlete Dilip Gavit aims to set world records in 100m, 400m

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

After setting a record en route to winning the 100m gold medal on his Commonwealth Games debut in Glasgow, para athlete Dilip Gavit is aiming even higher — he now hopes to break world records in both the 100m and 400m events at upcoming Para Asian Games in Japan.

"I want to set world records in the 100m and 400m at the Asian Games. At the 2022 Asian Games in Hangzhou, I won gold in the 400m. It was my first time competing in the 100m at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, and I won the gold medal with a Games record," said Gavit, who competes in the T47 category, on the sidelines of a felicitation ceremony organised by Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya to honour para athletes who won medals at the CWG.

"I want to run 10.28 seconds (close to India's able-bodied national record). Earlier, I competed in able-bodied events. I won gold medals at the national level among able-bodied athletes and at the Khelo India Games.

Back then, I mainly competed in the 400m," he said. The T47 category is for athletes with upper limb impairments, including unilateral arm amputation or reduced function in one arm, which can affect balance, coordination and running mechanics. Gavit felt that competition at Asian Games would be much tougher. "I'll be competing in both 400m and 100m. The level of competition will be higher. My coach will prepare me accordingly."

Asked how challenging it was to compete in two different events, Gavit said he enjoyed running both without any pressure.

"I usually compete in 400m, so running the 100m wasn't difficult for me. I just had to sprint. I wasn't under any pressure because I enjoy 100m. I just went out, sprinted and had a lot of fun racing," he said. (PTI)



Hockey goalkeeper Mohith ready to realise lifelong dream in WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

At 24 years, accidental goalkeeper Mohith HS of Karnataka is set to realise his lifelong dream of representing India at FIH Hockey World Cup, which will be jointed hosted by Netherlands and Belgium from August 15 to 30.

Alongside the experienced Suraj Karkera, Mohith is one of the two goalkeepers in the Indian team, marking another significant milestone in his remarkable journey.

While Mohith may not have the same level of international experience as Suraj, the young custodian has impressed consistently in recent months, particularly during the final leg of FIH Pro League season.



Abu Bakr Mahmood to lead Pakistan in men's hockey WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Striker Abu Bakr Mahmood will lead a 20-member Pakistan team in the FIH Men's Hockey World Cup to be held in the Netherlands and Belgium from August 15 to 30.

The national hockey selectors have retained former captain Ammad Shakeel Butt in the squad, which includes mostly those players who have been representing the country in recent international events.

The PHF is yet to give clarity on the coaching and management team for the World Cup in which Pakistan is taking part after eight years.

Pakistan are placed along side arch-rivals India, England and Wales in Pool D of the tournament. Pakistan will open their campaign against England at Amstelveen, Netherlands on August 15.

Pakistan squad: Waqar, Muhammad Abdullah,



Muhammad Sufyan Khan, Moeen Shakeel, Abdul Waheed Ashraf Rana, Abdul Hanan Shahid, Zakaria Hayat, Arshad Liaquat, Adil Latif, Ahmed Nadeem, Ghazanfar Ali, Ammad Shakeel Butt, Muhammad Hammaduddin Anjum, Rehman Abdul, Afraz, Umar Mustafa, Abu Bakar Mahmood (C), Ali Raza, Abdul Manan and Muhammad Ammad.

States get share in revamped Khelo India Scheme sports infrastructure development fund

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Revamping funding pattern of Khelo India Scheme, central government has set aside a ₹565 crore component for states which they will dip into to share the cost of future sports infrastructure development projects in the five-year plan.

The union cabinet, earlier this week, approved a ₹29,054 crore outlay for the Khelo India Scheme along with ₹7,387 crore for the Assistance to National Sports Federations Scheme (ANSF).

Revealing the finer details of the Khelo India Scheme fund, the sports ministry said the central share from the corpus would be ₹28,489 crore and the state share has been set



at ₹565 crore. However, the ministry did not provide details of the individual share allotted to each state. As per the scheme, the funding ratio for infrastructure development in general states would be 60:40 with the central government bearing majority of the cost.

For the North-Eastern (Arunachal Pradesh,

Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Sikkim, and Tripura) and Himalayan states (Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand), the central government would bear 90 per cent of the cost.

The infrastructure in Union Territories (Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Chandigarh, Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu, Delhi, Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh,



Lakshadweep, and Puducherry) would be entirely funded by the central government.

"This demarcation was not there in the previous Khelo India Scheme and this has been done to make states a partner in the process and provide them ownership in the projects," a Sports Ministry source said.

The new outlay is eight times the funds ear-



marked for the previous Khelo India Scheme, which only had provisions for central funding with no specific fund or role assigned to states. Currently, there are close to 3000 Khelo India Athletes across 22 sports. The sports ministry is hoping that the numbers would rise at least nine times "creating adequate bench strength."

The Ministry is aiming to utilise ANSF to support India's event-hosting ambitions, including this month's Badminton World Championships in Delhi. The Asian Athletics Relays next year and the World Athletics Indoor Championship in 2028 followed by the World Police and Fire Games in 2029 would also be funded through ANSF. The ANSF funds would also be used to prepare for the 2030 Commonwealth Games in Ahmedabad and support India's bid for 2036 Olympic and Paralympic Games.

‘No practice games for Australia before India Tests in 2027’

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Melbourne

Australia head coach Andrew McDonald has revealed that his team will not play any practice match before its high-profile Border Gavaskar Trophy away Test series against India next year as a short preparatory camp in conditions similar to the sub-continent would be more useful.

The much-anticipated five-Test series is scheduled to start on January 21 in Nagpur.

“We feel as though we’ve got enough time to immerse ourselves in those conditions. We won’t be taking on a practice game. It’ll just be more around the location,” McDonald told ‘cricket.com.au.’

“We’ve got a couple of options there. We have gone to the UAE previously and we have also gone into India last time into Bangalore, so we’re just working



through what that would look like in terms of how we then manage the individuals.”

The Australians will, however, play tour games against local sides during upcoming assignments against South

Africa and England.

The series against India would last for over a month with games spread across Nagpur, Chennai, Guwahati, and Ranchi before the finale in Ahmedabad.

During their 2023 tour of India, the Aussies had held a camp in Alur near Bengaluru to prepare for the series.

“Ultimately, if you can have a dedicated venue that you’re able to use and replicate as close to the conditions that you believe you may get in the first Test match or throughout a Test series, that’s ideally what you want,” he said.

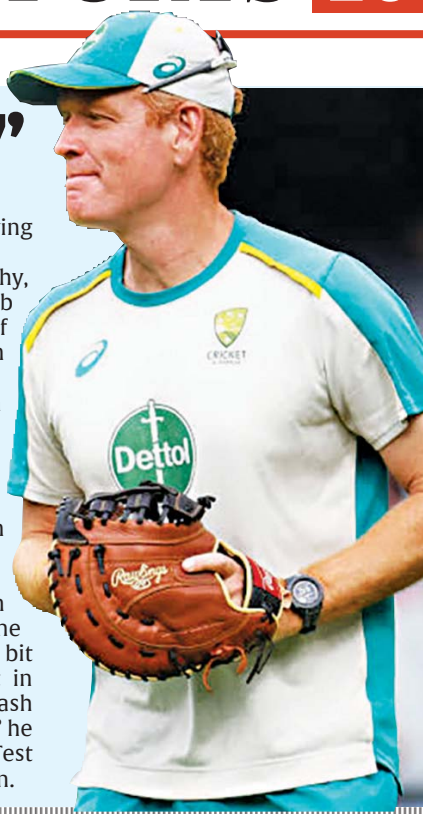
“You case those locations - you want a connection in terms of conditions and climate. We believe we’ll get that right in terms of where we go, it just hasn’t been confirmed yet.”

McDonald said players shortlisted for the India series but not in contention for the preceding home rubber against New Zealand would be expected to

prepare for the tour instead of playing in the Big Bash at that time.

Matthew Kuhnemann, Todd Murphy, Cooper Connolly, Peter Handscomb and Matthew Renshaw are some of the names in contention to play in India, according to the report.

“A lot of that would happen on the back of the four Tests against New Zealand, seeing where players are at. We’ll potentially have some different players with different skill sets that we believe can perform in India, so it won’t necessarily be the squad that finishes the Test series (against NZ that then heads to India). “There’ll be some players that we need to put a little bit more prep into, and that’ll start in Australia also, balancing out Big Bash commitments and things like that,” he said. Australian haven not won a Test series in India since 2004-05 season.



Last 10 months tested me in ways I never expected: Neeraj



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Opening about the fitness issues that he has been battling for close to a year, Indian javelin throw ace Neeraj Chopra said the last 10 months have tested him in ways that he never expected. The 28-year-old two-time Olympic medallist, who added a Commonwealth Games silver to his crowded cabinet last week, was primarily hampered by an adductor muscle injury and a few other niggles along with it.

His start to the season was delayed but he managed to find his rhythm at the CWG in Glasgow with a season’s best of 85.83m.

“There are throws that travel far, and then there are moments that carry the weight of an entire journey. The past 10 months has tested me in ways I never expected,” he posted on Instagram on Tuesday alongside a short clip of his CWG performance.

“Recovering from multiple injuries, rebuilding my body, finding my rhythm again, and learning to be patient when all I wanted was to compete. I was training every day without knowing if I will even have a season to compete this year,” he revealed. Chopra, who won gold in the 2018 Games in Gold Coast in Australia with a throw of 86.47m, missed the 2022 edition due to an injury.

Praggnanandhaa leads after rapid phase at St Louis, blitz next



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ St Louis (USA)

Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa topped the rapid section of the St. Louis Rapid and blitz, scoring 12 points out of a possible 18 to keep his hopes alive for a place in the Grand Chess Tour (GCT) finals to be held later this year.

The Indian, who is no longer a part of 2026 World Championship, displayed some immaculate technique, precision and the will to win in the rapid section that spanned over nine rounds in this annual edition that is a part of professional chess for several years now. Praggnanandhaa lost the ninth and final round in the rapid section to Dutch GM Jorden van Foreest but still managed to retain a one-point lead, finishing ahead of Uzbekistan’s Javokhir Sindarov, who will challenge D. Gukesh in the World Championship title showdown later this year. However, the GCT’s last rapid and blitz event is not just based on the rapid section but there are 18 more blitz games to be played before the winner is determined for the \$200,000 prize pool out of which \$50,000 goes to champion.

Had Praggnanandhaa defeated van Foreest, he would have entered the blitz section with a more comfortable lead, a margin that could have proved crucial in his pursuit of the overall title. Four wins, each worth two points, and four draws helped Praggnanandhaa finish atop the standings with 12 points despite a solitary loss in the final round.

With the rapid section behind him, the Indian will now turn his attention to the 18-game blitz segment, where each win carries one point.

CWG medallist Harsh eyes training stint ahead of Asian Games

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Having scripted history by becoming the first Indian male judoka to win a Commonwealth Games gold medal, Harsh Singh has already set his sights on next challenge.

The reigning champion hopes to train in Japan or Georgia ahead of next month’s Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, aiming to replicate his success on a much bigger stage.

“I want to go to Japan or Georgia. These two countries are ideal for Indian judokas. Along with Japan, Georgia is one of the strongest nations in judo. Training there will be



very beneficial for our future preparation. As we prepare for the next level, if we train under coaches who have achieved Olympic glory, we will be able to accomplish what we are

aiming for,” Harsh told PTI on the sidelines of a felicitation ceremony for the judokas here. Harsh said Indian judokas still trail the world’s best in technical aspects of the sport,

stressing that overseas training -- particularly under elite Japanese coaches -- is crucial to bridge the gap and compete at the highest level.

“I have not approached anyone yet... (but) Japanese coaches are strong in terms of experience and technique. We Indians are strong but we are a little behind in terms of technique. Footwork, and a bit more gripping... if we improve in these aspects, we will be able to perform better,” he said. The champion in Glasgow candidly admitted that the level of competition at the CWG was significantly lower than what he expects to face at the Asian Games. (PTI)

‘Satwik’s shoulder injury remains biggest concern ahead of Worlds’

AMIT KUMAR DAS ■ New Delhi

India’s men’s doubles coach Tan Kim Her on Wednesday said Satwiksairaj Rankireddy’s recurring shoulder injury remains the biggest concern ahead of the BWF World Championships, even as he backed the former world No. 1 pair to challenge for the title if they remain mentally strong.

Satwik and Chirag, bronze medallists at the 2022 and 2025 World Championships, head into this year’s edition after missing a few tournaments because of Satwik’s shoulder injury.

The Asian Games gold medallists, who returned to winning ways with the Singapore Open Super 750 title in June, have received a first-round bye as one of the seeded combinations.

“His shoulder is almost fully recovered now. He is ready now,” Tan told a select group of reporters on the sidelines of the draw ceremony for the World Championships, which begin here on August 17.

“He has gone under rehab. I think now he is improving a lot. Of course, the rehab is still there but he is getting much better. Chirag is fully 100 per cent fit.”



However, the Malaysian coach admitted that Satwik’s shoulder, which has troubled him since suffering a tear several years ago, continues to be a worry.

“Last year they had 8 semifinals and 2 finals. I think the results were quite consistent. And this year, Singapore has been the best tournament. Game-wise they are getting better now. Confidence? Okay. But what’s bothering them is the injury. That’s what’s bothering me and them also.

“So this one, especially for Satwik. His shoulder... he already had the tear. So it’s on and off. So hopefully this time he can overcome. This is my concern. Other than that, both of them are very committed, very disciplined. But injury there, we cannot do anything.” (PTI)

SA20: Mitchell Marsh joins Sunrisers, Sam Curran heads to Super Giants

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Johannesburg

Australia’s T20 skipper Mitchell Marsh is set to make his SA20 debut for the three-time champions, Sunrisers Eastern Cape, while England all-rounder Sam Curran will don the Durban’s Super Giants jersey after moving from MI Cape Town, as the six SA20 franchises secured their core squads ahead of the Season 5 auction on October 7.

Marsh will join Quinton de Kock, Matthew Breetzke, Jordan Hermann and captain Tristan Stubbs in a strong batting line-up at Sunrisers Eastern Cape (SEC), while Curran, who represented MI Cape Town in the first two seasons, will team up with his England teammate Jos Buttler.

Joe Root, who returned as England’s Test captain and formed a formidable opening partnership with young Lhuan-dre Pretorius for the Paarl Royals a couple of seasons ago, will return to the familiar surroundings of Boland Park for the upcoming season of the T20 tourna-



ment. Runners-up Pretoria Capitals have received a major boost to their top order with the additions of Phil Salt and Australian international Matt Short.

Salt, who previously represented the Capitals, will reunite with Short at the top of the order. The duo is expected to add more firepower to a batting line-up featuring Dewald Brevis, Sherfane Rutherford, Andre Russell and last season’s breakout star, Connor Esterhuizen.

England all-rounder Will Jacks, who had three fruitful seasons with the Capitals, has moved to MI Cape Town to

I don’t burden myself, focus on scoring as many runs: Smaran

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Bengaluru

At times, a 950-run season can hang around a batter’s neck like a millstone but Ravichandran Smaran has not overburdened himself with expectations, and is keen for an encore to remain in national reckoning. Smaran was the highest run-getter in the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy season, playing a vital role in Karnataka’s march to the final. He will launch his domestic campaign in Duleep Trophy.

“I don’t worry about expectations or burden myself with the thoughts of expectations on me as it is all about scoring as many runs as possible,” Smaran said. “It is all about practicing and training well ahead of a



season to be in the right mindset,” he added. But Smaran is keen to begin the new season on the right note, scoring heavily for South Zone in the Duleep Trophy to be played at the BCCI CoE. (PTI)

Alcaraz withdraws from the Cincinnati Open amid injury



MATTHEW DALY AND ERIC TUCKER ■ Cincinnati

Carlos Alcaraz withdrew Tuesday from the Cincinnati Open because of a lingering right wrist injury that has sidelined him since April. The No. 2-ranked Spaniard was hoping to return to defend his title in the hard-court tournament, which serves as an important warmup for the U.S. Open.

“We know Carlos is doing everything he can to get back to playing tournaments as soon as possible,” tournament director Bob Moran said in a statement. “We wish him the best with his recovery and look forward to welcoming him back to Cincinnati in the future.” Alcaraz last played at the Barcelona Open, then missed the French Open and the entire grass-court season, including Wimbledon.